

COLORS OF LIFE

A Novel

By Biswa Ranjan Panigrahi

CHAPTER I: THE WHITE APRON

PART 1

"Please... side... please... give a little side..."

The voice wasn't loud.

Yet it somehow managed to cut through every other noise in the casualty corridor.

A man arguing at the billing counter stopped midway.

The ward boy pushing an oxygen cylinder looked back.

Even the tea seller outside the entrance lifted his head for a moment.

The stretcher wasn't moving.

A wheelchair had been left carelessly across the corridor.

The old ward boy pushing the stretcher shook his head.

"Every day..."

He pushed the wheelchair aside himself.

"...people think hospitals have roads wider than highways."

The girl walking beside the stretcher smiled faintly.

Not because she found it funny.

Because she had no energy left to react.

Her left elbow was bleeding.

The cotton sleeve had torn.

Dust still clung to her palms.

She had not even washed them.

The old man lying on the stretcher looked strangely peaceful.

His eyes remained closed.

A thin stream of dried blood had travelled from his forehead to his left ear.

His white cotton shirt had almost become brown near the shoulder.

One rubber slipper still remained on his right foot.

The other...

had probably remained somewhere on the road.

The girl suddenly stopped.

Bent down.

Removed the remaining slipper.

Placed both slippers carefully beneath the stretcher.

The ward boy looked at her.

"You know him?"

She shook her head.

"No."

"Then why..."

She simply smiled.

"It doesn't look nice..."

"...wearing only one slipper."

The old ward boy looked at her for two seconds.

Then quietly resumed pushing the stretcher.

Government hospitals teach people many things.

Kindness...

usually isn't one of them.

Yet sometimes...

someone unexpectedly remembers it.

"Casualty!"

the nurse shouted without looking up from her register.

"Case?"

"Road accident."

"Name?"

The ward boy looked at the girl.

The girl looked at the old man.

"...Budha Baba."

The nurse continued writing.

"Full name?"

"I don't know."

Now the nurse looked up.

"You don't know?"

"No."

"Father's name?"

"I don't know."

"Age?"

"Maybe..."

"...seventy."

"Address?"

"I don't know."

The nurse slowly closed the register.

"You brought an unknown old man to the hospital?"

The girl nodded.

"He was bleeding."

"So?"

"I brought him."

The nurse looked at her as though expecting another explanation.

None came.

The ward boy interrupted.

"Madam..."

bike hit him near Saraswati Government School."

"Hit and run."

The nurse sighed.

"Every day..."

She reopened the register.

"Relationship?"

The pen remained waiting.

The girl didn't answer.

"Relative?"

"No."

"Daughter?"

"No."

"Neighbour?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I run an NGO nearby."

The nurse wrote.

NGO Volunteer.

"Sign here."

The girl signed without reading.

The stretcher disappeared inside the emergency room.

Only then did she realise...

she was still holding the old man's walking stick.

Nobody had noticed.

She looked at it carefully.

An ordinary bamboo stick.

Smooth near the handle.

Worn out near the bottom.

Someone had tied a tiny strip of red cloth at the top.

Perhaps to recognise it quickly.

She quietly kept it beside the ICU door.

As if the old man would immediately ask for it after waking up.

Inside...

the emergency room had already become another world.

"BP dropping."

"Pulse?"

"Seventy..."

"No... sixty-eight..."

"Suction."

"Gauze."

"Another IV line."

"Move."

One patient cried.

Another abused the hospital.

Somebody's child wouldn't stop coughing.

A woman fainted after seeing blood.

A ward boy searched for a missing oxygen mask.

Everything happened together.

Nobody had time to notice anyone else's problem.

Except...

the girl.

She stood outside the half-open door.

Every time someone crossed between her and the stretcher...

she instinctively shifted sideways to see whether the old man was still there.

As though he might quietly disappear if she lost sight of him.

"Madam."

She turned.

The receptionist stood holding a form.

"Admission."

She followed him.

Name.

Again she stopped.

Finally she wrote...

Budha Baba

Age.

Approximately 70.

Address.

Unknown.

Phone.

She wrote her own number.

The next column remained blank.

Relation with patient

The receptionist tapped the table.

"Madam..."

She held the pen.

Thought for a moment.

Then slowly wrote...

Human

The receptionist almost laughed.

"This is not an essay."

She looked at him.

"I know."

"Write proper relation."

She quietly struck it out.

Then wrote...

NGO Volunteer

At that exact moment...

the old Nokia phone inside her handbag started vibrating.

She looked at the screen.

School Office

She answered immediately.

"Hello."

"Didi..."

children know."

"What?"

"They know Baba met with an accident."

"Who told them?"

"The auto uncle."

She closed her eyes.

"They're crying."

"I'll come later."

"No...

they're refusing lunch."

"I said I'll come."

She disconnected.

The phone vibrated again.

Milk Anna

Then...

Temple Pujari

Then...

Old Age Home

Then...

Vegetable Market

Every caller asked exactly one question.

"How is Baba?"

She answered every one of them exactly the same way.

"Doctor is treating him."

Within twenty minutes...

the corridor had started changing.

A flower seller arrived carrying two unsold garlands.

A school teacher came directly from class.

An old postman still wearing his faded khaki uniform.

A tailor.

A bus conductor.

A fruit vendor pushing his cart.

A college student carrying a backpack.

Nobody knew each other.

Yet every one of them walked to the same ICU door.

Nobody asked where to stand.

Nobody spoke loudly.

Nobody demanded updates.

They simply waited.

The receptionist slowly looked up from his computer.

Then towards the security guard.

"Who is this old man?"

The security guard shrugged.

"No idea."

"But..."

He looked outside.

"...the crowd keeps growing."

PART 2

The corridor had become unusually silent.

Government hospitals never become silent.

They merely change the reason for their noise.

The casualty nurse came out holding a small blood sample.

"O positive?"

she shouted towards the laboratory attendant.

He looked at the request slip.

"First testing."

"Don't assume."

She almost threw the sample into his hand.

"Run."

He disappeared.

The old NGO volunteer slowly walked towards the emergency room door.

"Can I..."

"No."

The nurse didn't even look at her.

She had probably answered the same question a hundred times that day.

The girl quietly stepped back.

A little boy, hardly eight years old, came running.

"Didi..."

He held a steel tiffin box.

"School lunch."

She smiled for the first time.

"You came alone?"

He nodded proudly.

"Cycle."

She opened the tiffin.

Four rotis.

Potato curry.

A small piece of jaggery wrapped in newspaper.

"Baba didn't eat today."

the boy said.

"He said he'll eat after telling us the crow story."

She looked towards the ICU.

"He'll tell."

The boy believed her immediately.

Children have strange faith.

Adults ask for proof.

The nurse came out again.

"Attendant."

The girl hurried.

"Blood loss is more than expected."

She simply nodded.

"We may need blood."

"I'll give."

The answer came so quickly that the nurse didn't even raise her head.

"Good."

She wrote something.

"Come."

The girl followed.

Blood bank.

A narrow room.

One old ceiling fan.

Three plastic chairs.

One weighing machine.

A calendar still showing last month.

The technician looked sleepy.

"Name?"

She answered.

He filled the form.

"Age?"

She answered.

"Weight?"

She answered.

Then...

"Any illness?"

Silence.

He looked up.

"Madam?"

She looked at the floor.

"...Yes."

"What?"

Another silence.

The nurse became impatient.

"Madam..."

we don't have time."

The girl slowly raised her eyes.

"I..."

"...have AIDS."

The room became completely still.

Even the fan suddenly sounded louder.

The technician quietly kept his pen down.

The nurse stared at her.

For a second...

there was irritation.

Then guilt.

Then embarrassment.

She spoke much more softly this time.

"I'm sorry."

The girl smiled.

"It is alright."

"I asked to give blood."

"I never said I could."

Nobody spoke.

After a few seconds the technician quietly tore the half-filled form.

Without saying anything.

The girl folded her hands.

"I'm sorry."

The nurse looked away.

"No..."

you don't have to be."

She left.

Outside...

two ward boys had already heard the conversation.

One whispered to another.

Within a minute...

half the corridor knew.

The same people who had stood shoulder to shoulder with her...

now unknowingly made a little space around her.

Not much.

Just enough to hurt.

She noticed.

Pretended not to.

Walked back to her chair.

Sat down.

Looked towards the ICU.

Nothing else mattered.

The little boy came running again.

"Didi."

"Can I see Baba once?"

"No."

"When?"

"When he wakes up."

The boy accepted the answer.

Children trust promises.

Adults remember excuses.

The laboratory attendant came running.

"O positive."

The nurse looked around.

"Relative?"

Nobody answered.

She shouted louder.

"Any relative of Baba?"

Silence.

The NGO girl stood up.

"He has no family."

The nurse almost lost her patience.

"What kind of life is this..."

she muttered.

Before she could finish...

someone from the crowd stepped forward.

"I'll give."

Everyone turned.

It was the flower seller.

Immediately...

the retired postman came beside him.

"My blood is also O positive."

The security guard raised his hand.

"Mine too."

The college student looked confused.

"I don't know my group..."

test mine."

The auto driver spoke from behind.

"If needed..."

take mine first.

He was in my auto."

The nurse looked at them.

One after another...

people kept walking forward.

A tea seller.

A tailor.

A bus conductor.

The old woman who sold jasmine flowers outside the temple.

Within two minutes...

there were fifteen people standing in a queue.

Nobody asked

"Who is he?"

Nobody asked

"What relation?"

Nobody asked

"Will someone pay?"

They simply stood there.

The laboratory technician came out.

Stopped.

Counted the queue.

Looked at the nurse.

Then smiled.

"For the first time..."

he said,

"...I have more donors than blood bags."

The nurse looked through the glass towards the unconscious old man.

She whispered almost to herself.

"Who are you, Baba?"

The answer came from somewhere behind.

A familiar voice.

Quiet.

Respectful.

"Ask anyone outside."

"They'll tell you."

"But don't ask Baba himself."

"He never tells."

The crowd slowly turned.

An old tea vendor had just arrived.

He removed his slippers before standing near the ICU door.

Folded his hands.

Closed his eyes.

And smiled...

as though he had just come to visit someone from his own family. The corridor had become unusually silent.

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PART 3

The casualty door opened again.

This time...

a different doctor entered.

Younger than others.

White coat still looked new.

Stethoscope carefully placed around neck.

Not hanging carelessly like experienced doctors.

He walked towards the nurses' station.

Stopped.

Looked at the unusual crowd near ICU.

"What happened?"

The receptionist looked up.

"Road accident case."

"Anyone serious?"

"Old man."

"Name?"

The receptionist checked the register.

"Vikram Ahuja."

The doctor's hand stopped midway while signing the attendance sheet.

He looked up slowly.

"What?"

"Vikram Ahuja."

"Age?"

"Around fifty."

The doctor stood completely still.

The receptionist noticed.

"Sir...

you know him?"

No answer.

The doctor simply walked towards the ICU.

Slowly.

As though he was trying to remember something.

Or perhaps...

trying to forget.

Inside the ICU...

the old man remained unconscious.

Monitors beeped regularly.

IV drips continued.

Oxygen mask covered half his face.

The doctor stood outside the glass door.

Stared at the patient.

One minute passed.

Then another.

The senior nurse came beside him.

"Dr. Tripathy...

patient is stable now."

He didn't respond.

She looked at him carefully.

"You know him?"

He finally spoke.

Very softly.

"I don't know."

"What?"

"I knew someone..."

He stopped.

"Long time ago."

"Same name?"

"Yes."

"Same person?"

The doctor looked at the unconscious face.

Forehead bandaged.

Dried blood still visible near the ear.

White beard.

Wrinkled skin.

Old cotton shirt.

Rubber slippers kept under the stretcher.

"I don't know."

The nurse handed him the case sheet without looking up from her logbook.

"Admitted at midnight," she said.

Adarsh took the plastic folder.

He opened it.

Date of birth.

07-07-1977.

He calculated quickly.

Around fifty.

Matched.

Father's name.

Binay Ahuja.

His hand trembled slightly.

Address.

Unknown.

Occupation.

Unknown.

Relationship with attendant.

NGO Volunteer.

He closed the file.

Looked again at the old man.

Then quietly walked away.

The nurse called behind him.

"Sir...

you know him or not?"

He stopped near the exit.

Turned back.

"I knew someone named Vikram Ahuja."

"But..."

He looked one more time towards the ICU.

"...that Vikram would never become Budha Baba."

Dr. Adarsh Tripathy walked towards the canteen.

Not because he wanted tea.

Because he needed time to think.

The hospital canteen was always the same.

Old plastic chairs.

Stained tables.

One ceiling fan rotating slowly.

Tea that tasted exactly like yesterday's tea.

He sat in the corner.

Ordered nothing.

Simply stared at the wall.

Vikram Ahuja.

Binay Ahuja.

Date of birth 07-07-1977.

Everything matched.

Yet everything felt wrong.

That Vikram wore branded clothes.

This Budha Baba wore torn cotton.

That Vikram was always surrounded by friends.

This old man was brought by an NGO volunteer.

That Vikram talked about building companies.

This man...

apparently told crow stories to school children.

The tea seller came to his table anyway.

"Sir...

regular?"

Adarsh nodded without looking.

The tea arrived.

He held the glass.

Felt the warmth.

Remembered.

Twenty-eight years ago.

1995.

The year everything began.

He was eighteen then.

First year MBBS.

Anatomy practical.

The dissection hall smelled exactly how dissection halls always smell.

Formaldehyde.

Steel trays.

A chart of the human skeleton on the wall.

Forty students.

Ten dissection tables.

Complete chaos.

"Where is my scalpel?"

"Who took the forceps?"

"Sir..."

the specimen is missing a label."

"Careful..."

careful..."

Someone knocked over a jar.

Laughter.

Then scolding.

Then normal again.

Adarsh stood near table seven.

Alone.

His partner hadn't arrived yet.

The lab assistant distributed white aprons.

"Wear properly."

"This is not chemistry.

Respect the body."

"Breakage of instruments will be charged."

Nobody listened completely.

Everyone wore aprons carelessly.

Except one boy.

He wore it carefully.

Tied the strings properly.

Checked the pockets.

Then quietly walked towards table seven.

Looked at Adarsh.

"Partner?"

Adarsh nodded.

The boy smiled slightly.

Extended his hand.

"Vicky."

Adarsh shook hands.

"Adarsh."

"Tripathy?"

Adarsh was surprised.

"How do you know?"

Vicky pointed at the apron.

On the left pocket...

someone had stitched a name using blue thread.

Adarsh Tripathy

Small letters.

Neat stitching.

Mother's handiwork.

Adarsh felt embarrassed.

"My mother..."

Vicky's smile changed.

"My mom would have done the same."

A pause.

"But she is no more with me."

Adarsh didn't know what to say.

"Lost her.

Never seen."

Vicky's eyes went somewhere else.

Almost wet.

Then he blinked.

Came back.

Picked up the scalpel.

Checked its edge against the light.

Just like that.

Emotion appeared.

Then disappeared.

Adarsh said nothing.

"Sorry" felt too small.

They began the dissection.

Cutting.

Observing.

Labeling.

Very little conversation.

Just enough.

"Pass the forceps."

"Done?"

"Wait."

Midway through the practical...

the lab assistant shouted.

"Five minutes remaining."

Everyone hurried.

Mistakes increased.

Confusion increased.

Vicky remained calm.

Completed every step properly.

No hurry.

Adarsh noticed.

This boy was different.

Not showing off.

Simply focused.

Professor Khanna walked between the tables.

White beard.

Reputation for failing half the class.

He stopped at table seven.

Read the stitched name aloud.

"Adarsh Tripathy."

Adarsh froze.

"Your mother did this?"

"Yes, sir."

A pause.

Then the professor smiled.

"Good.

At least someone's mother believes her son will pass my class."

Scattered laughter.

He moved on.

Vicky whispered.

"Saved you."

"Saved me?"

He announced it to the whole hall."

"Better than announcing you can't hold a scalpel properly."

Fair point.

The bell rang.

"Submit your observations."

Everyone rushed towards the professor's desk.

Vicky and Adarsh submitted together.

Khanna checked.

Nodded.

"Good."

They removed their aprons.

Kept them on the rack.

Then walked out.

Outside the hall...

someone called.

"Aye..."

first year."

Four seniors stood near the staircase.

Second year students.

Ragging season.

Adarsh felt nervous.

Vicky remained calm.

The seniors walked closer.

"Name?"

Adarsh answered immediately.

"Adarsh Tripathy."

One senior laughed.

"Tripathy..."

Brahmin?"

"Yes."

"Bad luck.

General category.

No quota, no backup.

Pure merit for you, poor fellow."

Everyone laughed.

Adarsh said nothing.

Then they turned to Vicky.

"You?"

"Vicky."

The senior blinked.

"Vicky?"

He turned to the others.

"Vicky?"

That's a dog's name, yaar.

My cousin's Pomeranian is called Vicky."

Everyone laughed harder.

Vicky's face didn't change.

"Full name."

A pause.

Then he answered.

"Vikram Ahuja."

The laughter stopped.

"Ahuja...

business family?"

Vikram didn't answer.

The senior pressed.

"Rich family?"

"I don't know."

"You don't know if your family is rich?"

Laughter again.

Another senior interrupted.

"Arre leave him.

Look at his shoes.

Nike.

Definitely rich."

Vikram looked at his shoes.

Then at Adarsh's cheap rubber slippers.

He felt uncomfortable.

Not because of seniors.

Because of the comparison.

One senior stepped closer.

"First year riddle.

Answer fast."

Vikram waited.

"Which part of the body...

has no bone...

full flesh...

but most sensitive?

Nerve endings everywhere."

Silence.

Vikram's ears went red.

He looked at the ground.

Didn't answer.

Adarsh understood the trap.

Tried to help.

Pulled his own tongue out.

Wiggled it.

Pointed.

The seniors burst out laughing.

"Oye!

Pervert!

It's the tongue, man!

What were **you** thinking?"

Vikram's face went from red to redder.

"I... I knew that."

"Sure you did."

More laughter.

The senior wasn't finished.

"Next one.

Which part...

if you put a finger inside...

water comes out?"

Vikram, still flustered, blurted the first thing.

"Eye."

The seniors erupted.

"Eye?

Bro!

Should I put my finger in your eye and check?

Let's see how much water comes out."

Laughter loud enough for two floors below.

Even Adarsh laughed this time.

Vikram's ears stayed red.

Then he laughed too.

Small.

Reluctant.

But real.

The senior turned to Adarsh.

"You.

Sing a song."

Adarsh's throat closed.

He sang two lines.

Badly.

"Enough.

Terrible voice.

Go."

They didn't dismiss Vikram.

"You.

Stay."

Vikram glanced at Adarsh.

A small shake of the head.

Go.

Adarsh walked a few steps.

Slowed down.

Listened.

"Rich boy.

You think your papa's money matters here?"

"No."

"Good.

Remember that."

Footsteps.

Vikram caught up near the gate.

Neither spoke for a while.

Then Adarsh asked.

"Your name...

Bikram or Vikram?"

"Vikram."

"Why did you say Vicky?"

Vikram smiled.

Small.

Tired.

"Everyone calls me Vicky."

"Why?"

"Easier."

They reached the canteen.

Ordered tea.

Sat on the wooden bench outside.

Afternoon sun.

Tree shade.

Neither spoke for a while.

First day of friendship.

Neither of them knew then...

that this friendship would last almost three decades.

Neither of them knew...

that one day Adarsh would stand in a hospital corridor,

staring at an unconscious old man,

trying to believe that Vicky and Budha Baba were the same person.

Dr. Adarsh Tripathy opened his eyes.

The hospital canteen returned.

His tea had become cold.

He hadn't taken a single sip.

The tea seller asked.

"Sir...

shall I change it?"

Adarsh looked at the glass.

Shook his head.

"No."

He stood up.

Walked back towards the casualty.

The crowd near ICU had grown even larger.

Someone had brought flowers.

Someone had brought fruits.

A small child held a hand-drawn greeting card.

The NGO girl still sat on the same chair.

Holding the walking stick.

Waiting.

Adarsh stood at a distance.

Watched everything.

Then slowly walked towards the ICU door.

The nurse saw him.

"Sir...

did you remember?"

He nodded.

"College friend."

"You are sure?"

"Same name.

Same father's name.

Same date of birth."

"Then why did you say you don't know?"

Adarsh looked through the glass at the unconscious man.

"Because..."

He stopped.

How could he explain?

The Vikram he knew...

was supposed to become something else.

Not this.

The nurse waited for the answer.

Adarsh simply said.

"Because I don't know what happened between then and now."

He walked away.

But his mind remained inside the ICU.

That evening...

Budha Baba's condition improved.

Blood transfusion completed.

Bleeding stopped.

Vitals stable.

The senior doctor allowed one visitor.

The NGO girl immediately stood up.

She entered the ICU.

Stood beside the bed.

Looked at the old man.

His eyes remained closed.

But breathing had become normal.

She didn't say anything.

Simply kept her hand on his.

Very softly.

As though reassuring herself he was still alive.

After two minutes...

she quietly left.

Outside...

the entire crowd looked at her.

Waiting for news.

She smiled.

"He is better."

Relief.

Immediately...

the little boy shouted.

"Baba will tell the crow story now!"

Everyone smiled.

Even the serious-looking security guard.

The NGO girl sat back on her chair.

This time...

she finally noticed her own injury.

Blood had dried on her elbow.

The sleeve was torn.

She hadn't even cleaned it.

A nurse came with cotton and Dettol.

"Let me see."

The girl hesitated.

The nurse understood.

"I know.

AIDS.

I'll be careful."

She cleaned the wound.

Applied bandage.

"You should have treated this first."

The girl smiled.

"Baba was more important."

"Why?"

The girl looked towards the ICU.

"Because..."

She tried to find words.

"...he taught me that life is bigger than diseases."

The nurse didn't understand completely.

But she didn't ask more.

Dr. Adarsh Tripathy completed his duty at 8 PM.

Signed the register.

Removed his white coat.

But didn't leave immediately.

He walked back towards the ICU one more time.

The crowd had reduced slightly.

But the NGO girl still remained.

He stood beside her.

She looked up.

"Doctor sahib...

he will recover na?"

Adarsh nodded.

"He will."

"When can we take him home?"

"Few days."

She nodded.

Relieved.

Adarsh hesitated.

Then asked.

"You know him since long?"

"Three years."

"How did you meet him?"

She smiled.

"He came to our NGO.

Said he wants to teach children.

No salary.

Just time pass."

Adarsh felt strange hearing this.

Vikram Ahuja.

Son of Binay Ahuja.

Teaching children.

Time pass.

Something didn't fit.

"What does he teach?"

"Everything.

Maths.

Science.

Stories.

Life."

"Where does he live?"

"Near the NGO.

Small room."

"Alone?"

"Yes."

"No family?"

The girl thought for a moment.

"Baba never talks about family."

Adarsh wanted to ask more.

But he stopped.

Instead he asked something else.

"What is your name?"

"Ananya."

"You work in NGO?"

"Yes.

HIV awareness program."

Adarsh understood why she had AIDS.

Probably contracted during awareness work.

Or perhaps before joining.

He didn't ask.

Some questions remain unasked.

"Thank you for bringing him here."

Ananya smiled.

"I should thank him.

He brought me here three years ago.

Same hospital.

Different reason."

Adarsh didn't understand.

She continued.

"When I got HIV report...

I tried to end my life.

Pills.

Hospital.

Stomach wash.

Baba was the only one who visited.

Every single day.

Until I walked out alive."

She looked at Adarsh.

"Today...

I returned the favor."

Adarsh said nothing.

Simply nodded.

Then quietly left.

Outside the hospital...

the night had become completely dark.

Auto rickshaws honked.

Street vendors shouted.

Normal city life.

Adarsh stood near the gate.

Tried to process everything.

Vikram Ahuja.

Budha Baba.

Same person.

Different life.

What happened?

He knew only one thing clearly.

Tomorrow...

when Vikram wakes up...

he will ask.

Not as a doctor.

As an old friend.

Back in the ICU...

around 11 PM...

something changed.

The monitor beeped differently.

The duty nurse noticed.

Checked vitals.

Then smiled.

Patient was waking up.

She informed the senior doctor.

He came immediately.

Checked everything.

"Good.

Consciousness returning.

Keep monitoring."

Around 11:30 PM...

the old man's eyes slowly opened.

First confused.

Then focused.

He saw the white ceiling.

Hospital smell.

Beeping machines.

He tried to remember.

Road.

Auto.

Sudden crash.

Children screaming.

Ananya's voice.

Then darkness.

He tried to speak.

Nothing came out.

Throat dry.

The nurse came closer.

"Baba...

you are in hospital.

Don't worry.

You are safe now."

He blinked.

Trying to understand.

She gave him water.

Few drops.

He drank slowly.

Then whispered.

"Ananya?"

"Outside.

Waiting."

He tried to sit.

"Careful Baba."

He lay back.

Closed his eyes again.

But this time...

not unconscious.

Just tired.

Very tired.

The nurse stepped out.

Told Ananya.

"He woke up.

Asked for you."

Ananya smiled.

Tears came suddenly.

Relief.

She didn't enter.

Just folded her hands towards the ICU.

"Thank you."

To whom?

God?

Doctors?

Life itself?

Nobody knew.

Perhaps she herself didn't know.

That night...

Dr. Adarsh couldn't sleep.

He kept thinking.

Vikram Ahuja.

07-07-1977.

Chemistry lab.

White apron.

Mother's stitched name.

First meeting.

Then what?

What happened after college?

Where did he go?

Why didn't they stay in touch?

How did Vikram become Budha Baba?

Questions without answers.

He knew tomorrow he would get some answers.

But he also knew...

some questions would remain forever.

Because...

the distance between a college laboratory and a hospital ICU...

is never just years.

Sometimes...

it's an entire lifetime.

[End of Part 3]

CHAPTER II: THE BLUE COLLAR

PART 1

Winter, 1996/97.

Second year MBBS.

Six months into second year.

Evening.

Adarsh knocked on Vikram's door.

No answer.

He pushed it open.

Empty.

Textbooks open on the desk.

Pathology.

Half-underlined.

Tea gone cold in a steel tumbler.

Full tumbler.

Vikram never left tea unfinished.

Not once in six months.

Adarsh noticed that before he noticed anything else.

Adarsh checked the corridor.

Nothing.

He walked down towards the warden's office.

There was one phone in the hostel.

Black.

Rotary dial.

Chained to the wall outside the warden's room.

Everyone used it.

Everyone waited in line for it.

Tonight there was no line.

Just Vikram.

Standing.

Receiver against his ear.

Not speaking.

Just listening.

Adarsh slowed down.

Something in the way Vikram stood.

Shoulders too still.

Adarsh didn't go closer.

Waited near the stairs.

"...

when?"

Vikram's voice.

Barely audible.

The line crackled.

Trunk call, routed through two exchanges, the operator's voice cutting in once — "Connected, go ahead" — then static.

"...

how bad?"

The line went dead mid-sentence.

Vikram stood there, receiver still pressed to his ear, listening to nothing.

Then dialled again.

Got through.

"...

say it again."

Silence.

Then.

"I'm coming.

Tonight."

He put the receiver down.

Didn't move.

Stood there.

Staring at the wall in front of him.

The bulb above the phone flickered.

Buzzed.

Steadied again.

Adarsh walked over.

"Vicky?"

No response.

"Vicky."

Vikram turned.

His face...

Adarsh had never seen it like that.

Not sad exactly.

Emptied.

"Papa."

He stopped there.

Adarsh waited.

"They said liver.

Then they said a word I made him repeat twice."

"What word?"

"Decompensated."

Adarsh felt his own stomach drop.

He knew the word.

Pathology, third chapter, the one neither of them had properly finished.

"That doesn't mean—"

"I know what it means and what it doesn't."

Vikram's voice was flat.

"It means nobody can tell me yet if he has one bad month or five good years.

Uncle just kept saying 'we'll see, we'll see.'

I've never heard a doctor sound more useless."

Adarsh didn't know what to say.

Nobody teaches you what to say.

Not even in a medical college.

"I need to go home."

"I'll come with—"

"No."

Too fast.

Vikram softened it.

"No.

Stay.

Exams are close.

I'll go alone."

"Vicky, this isn't about exams—"

"I know what it's about."

Sharp.

Then immediately, quieter.

"Sorry."

Adarsh said nothing.

Followed him back to the room.

Vikram pulled out a bag.

Started throwing things in.

Two shirts.

Then his hand went to the shelf.

Stopped at the dissection kit.

Small steel instruments, wrapped in cloth, the ones he'd kept wound tight and oiled since first year.

He almost packed it.

Didn't.

Put it back exactly where it was, like leaving a place for something to return to.

Then he looked at the desk.

Pathology textbook.

Half-underlined.

He picked it up.

Held it for a second.

Put it back down.

Didn't pack it.

Adarsh noticed.

Said nothing.

Vikram zipped the bag.

Looked around the room once.

As if checking he wasn't forgetting something.

He was forgetting nothing.

He was leaving something.

"There's a train at 11," he said.

"I'll make it if I leave now."

Adarsh walked him to the gate.

Night had settled fully.

Crickets somewhere.

A stray dog followed them halfway, then lost interest.

At the gate, Vikram stopped.

Turned to Adarsh.

"If I don't come back for the practical exam—"

"You'll come back."

"If I don't—"

"Vicky."

Vikram exhaled.

"Papa always wanted a doctor in the family.

He used to tell relatives.

'My son will wear the white coat.'

Proudly.

Like it was already done."

He looked at his hands.

"I don't think that's happening now."

"Don't decide anything tonight."

"I'm not deciding.

I'm just telling you what I already know."

A rickshaw turned in at the hostel gate, headlights sweeping across them.

Vikram picked up his bag.

"Tell the professor.

Family emergency.

I'll write when I know more."

"Vicky—"

He was already walking towards the rickshaw.

Half-turned back.

"Thanks for not asking if I'm okay."

Adarsh hadn't even thought to ask.

Some questions you don't ask a man carrying a bag at 10 PM because his father might be dying, or might not, and nobody will say which for weeks.

The rickshaw pulled away.

Red tail-light shrinking down the dark road.

Adarsh stood at the gate a long time.

Then walked back to Vikram's room.

The door was still open.

He looked at the desk.

Pathology textbook.

Half-underlined.

Left behind.

He picked it up.

Closed it.

Kept it safely in the cupboard.

Waiting for a return that would take twenty-two years.

Vikram never came back for the practical exam.

Or the next semester.

Or the one after.

The name stayed on the college register for one more year.

Struck off eventually.

Nobody in the hostel talked about it for long.

New batch arrived.

New rumors replaced old ones.

Adarsh kept the pathology textbook for a while.

Then, packing to leave hostel himself years later, he found it again.

Half-underlined.

Dust on the cover.

He didn't know where to send it.

He never found out the address.

He kept it anyway.

Every year, around the same winter week, he'd open that cupboard and find it still there.

Dust a little thicker.

He never asked himself why he hadn't thrown it out.

He just closed the cupboard again.

PART 2

The hospital corridor smelled of Dettol and overcooked rice from the visitors' canteen.

Vikram found the room by counting doors, not by asking anyone.

His father was not sitting up reading files.

That version of this scene existed only in the ones Vikram had built on the train.

The real one: Binay Ahuja lay propped on two flat pillows, skin gone the color of weak tea, a saline line taped crooked into the back of his hand.

Awake.

Watching the door.

"You came," Binay said.

Not a question.

"Papa."

"Sit."

Vikram sat.

For a while neither of them said the thing that needed saying, and instead said the things that fill the space before it.

"Rohan ate?"

"I don't know, Papa."

"Someone should check."

"I'll check."

"Sit first."

Vikram sat back down.

*A young resident doctor came in, flipped a chart, said words like **portal hypertension** and **we'll monitor** and **let's see how he responds** in the tone doctors use when they don't yet know which sentence they'll need to say next week.*

Vikram, second year, understood exactly enough of the words to know that not knowing was the actual diagnosis.

The resident left.

Binay watched him go.

"He talks like your professors," Binay said. "Confident about being unsure."

"That's the job, Papa."

"Was going to be your job too."

Vikram said nothing.

"I told Sharma-ji at the club last year.

My son, wait and watch, one day, big doctor.

I said it like it was already sitting in my pocket."

He looked at the saline line in his own hand like it belonged to someone else.

"Seems fate had a different item in that pocket."

"Papa, don't—"

"I'm not being dramatic.

I'm being accurate."

A silence that had weight to it.

Then Binay did something Vikram didn't expect.

He looked almost embarrassed.

"I have to ask you something and I don't like asking it."

"Ask."

"Can you stay some weeks.

Just to look after things at the office.

Nothing big.

Sign what Pradhan-babu tells you to sign.

Rohan is sixteen, still in school, can't be there every day."

"Some weeks," Vikram repeated.

"That's all I'm asking."

It did not feel like all he was asking.

It felt like the first sentence of something much longer, spoken deliberately small so it could be agreed to.

Vikram said yes anyway.

What else does a nineteen-year-old say to a father with a tube in his hand.

Pradhan-babu turned out to be sixty-one years old, wore the same brown cardigan every day regardless of weather, and had worked for Binay Ahuja since before Vikram was born.

His office was one room, one ceiling fan missing a blade, and a typewriter that jammed on the letter 'M'.

"Sign here, sign here, and here," he told Vikram the first morning, sliding three ledgers across.

Vikram signed.

"Not like that."

"Like what?"

"Full signature.

Not initials.

Bank won't accept initials from a new signatory."

Vikram signed again, slower, the letters coming out wrong-sized, a schoolboy's hand trying to look official.

Pradhan-babu watched him do it twice more before it looked acceptable.

Didn't comment.

Just refiled the ledger.

At noon, a factory supervisor from the malt unit came to the office, twisting his cap in both hands, waiting to speak to "Ahuja Sahib."

Vikram stood to greet him properly, the way you greet a senior doctor doing rounds.

"Sir," Vikram said, before he could stop himself.

The supervisor blinked.

Looked behind him to check who Vikram was addressing.

Nobody was there.

Pradhan-babu, from his desk, without looking up: "You're Ahuja Sahib now.

People say sir to you.

Not the other way."

Vikram felt his ears go warm, the exact same warmth from a different room, a different year, a stitched name on an apron.

He straightened.

Tried again.

"Yes, tell me. What's the problem at the unit?"

Better.

Not good.

Better.

Some weeks became six weeks.

Six weeks became a semester he didn't return for.

Binay came home from the hospital thinner than before, walking slower, but home — the crisis, whatever it truly was, had loosened its grip without fully letting go.

He never again mentioned the boy who was going to wear a white coat.

Vikram never again mentioned the exam he'd missed, then the one after.

Some things are easier to leave unfinished than to formally end.

The pathology textbook stayed behind in a hostel two hundred kilometers away, in a friend's cupboard neither of them thought about often.

The signature got better.

The "sir" stopped catching in his throat.

Nobody in that office remembered, within a year, that he had ever hesitated.

Vikram remembered.

He just stopped mentioning it.

PART 3

By twenty-six, Vikram's name appeared in a business magazine's "Ones to Watch" list.

By twenty-eight, the same magazine dropped the "Watch" and just wrote his name.

By twenty-nine, three years running, a Forbes list carried him too — always somewhere in the lower half, always misspelling Ahuja as Ahluja in at least one edition, which annoyed Pradhan-babu more than it annoyed Vikram.

None of it had happened in the South.

Not one factory, not one office, nothing below the Godavari.

That map stayed blank on purpose — or, more honestly, out of caution nobody had yet forced him past.

The government's new liquor policy arrived like most government policies arrive — as a rumor two months before it was a rule, and a crisis the week after.

New licensing slabs.

Higher duty.

A minister who'd never visited a distillery in his life explaining distillery economics on television with great confidence.

Pradhan-babu, now with a second cardigan for winter, aged but unretired, put it plainly.

"Sir, if this policy stands as drafted, we lose the Odisha license by March."

"Then it won't stand as drafted."

"You're going to fight the state government?"

"I'm going to make sure the state government understands what four thousand jobs look like on paper before they sign anything."

It took eleven months, two industry associations, one strategically-timed press conference, and a compromise nobody loved equally.

The license survived.

Vikram didn't celebrate.

He went home, ate dinner alone, and read the fine print of the amended policy twice, the way some men reread a letter from someone they miss.

Ira Sen came to interview him for that same press conference.

Business desk, a mid-size paper with ambitions of a bigger one.

She asked sharper questions than the ones from bigger papers.

"Everyone talks about the license survival. Nobody's asking what it cost you personally to fight it."

Nobody had asked him that in eleven months.

"Is that an interview question?"

"No," she said. "That one's for me."

He liked that she said it.

The second interview never happened, officially — she came back to "fact-check one quote" and stayed for dinner instead, and neither of them ever filed that particular follow-up story.

She had a way of sitting across a table that made boardrooms feel like a different profession entirely — elbows on the wood, chin low over folded hands, watching him the way she watched a source about to say something he shouldn't.

"You're doing it again," he told her once.

"Doing what?"

"Interviewing me. Off the record."

"Everything's off the record with you until you decide otherwise."

He decided otherwise, slowly, over that autumn.

Their first evening alone lasted until neither of them noticed the driver had circled the block four times waiting for a call that never came.

Streetlight through the car window. Her hand finding the back of his neck, warm and slow, the way she was when she had finished the day's edits.

It was raining when they reached her apartment door.

She didn't speak. She took his keys, opened the door, and pulled him inside by his wet collar.

Her room smelled of old newsprint and jasmine agarbatti.

She worked his tie loose before either of them had said a word, her fingers warm against his collarbone.

Some nights they sat on the floor, her head resting against his chest, the city traffic outside dimming to a low hum. She would talk about a headline that had been cut, or the price of paper in Calcutta, and Vikram would listen, holding his glass of water, his shoulders dropping an inch on their own.

That was the thing the ledger never gave him.

Silence that asked for nothing back.

Other nights were faster — her hand tracing his neck in the dark, his mouth finding her shoulder, the dry, clean heat of her skin. They didn't talk about how long it would last. In their profession, you didn't ask for a guarantee before you read the story.

He never told Pradhan-babu why he started leaving the office by eight most evenings.

He never told Rohan why he'd started smiling at his phone at odd hours, a habit their father would have found, if he'd lived to see it, both endearing and faintly ridiculous.

He gave her, without her asking twice, a supplementary card on his account — the kind of gesture rich men make when they want love to feel like less of a transaction, and it always, invisibly, becomes one anyway.

That October, during Durga Puja week, she told him she had an assignment.

"Delhi. Festive coverage. Three days."

"Take the car to the airport."

"I'll take a cab, don't fuss."

He fussed anyway. Ordered a car for her from the office, driver and all, insisted.

She left for the airport, she said, on the Tuesday.

On Wednesday afternoon, his phone buzzed once — a transaction alert, the bank's dry little message, the kind he usually didn't even read.

Rs. 340 debited — Café Coffee Day, Salt Lake, near the press building.

He looked at it twice.

Salt Lake was eleven kilometers from the airport, and considerably farther from Delhi.

He almost called her.

Then thought: flight delayed, she's killing time near office before catching a later one, of course, why panic.

He had, that week, been meaning to give her something.

A car of her own — not office-arranged, hers, cream-colored, ribbon still in the boot because he hadn't decided yet whether that was too much or exactly enough.

He thought: if she's still in the city, let me surprise her before she leaves.

He drove it there himself.

The building security let him through without question; his face, by then, opened most doors in that city without needing a name.

Her cabin was on the second floor, glass-walled on one side, the blinds half down.

The door was ajar.

He didn't knock.

He'd never needed to before.

He pushed it open expecting to see her at her desk, phone to her ear, ready to be surprised.

What he saw instead took his mind a full two seconds longer to process than it should have — the kind of two seconds where the body understands before the brain agrees to.

Her blouse, unbuttoned wrong, hung off one shoulder.

A man's belt lay uncoiled on the floor near the desk leg — Rajeev, junior sub-editor, someone Vikram had shaken hands with twice at office parties and forgotten both times.

Underwear — hers, his — scattered without any pretense of having been placed rather than dropped.

Neither of them heard the door.

For one full second, nobody in that room moved.

Vikram didn't shout.

Didn't ask a single question he already had every answer to.

He stepped back.

Closed the door as quietly as he had opened it — quieter, if anything, as though the one courtesy left to give was silence.

Downstairs, the cream-colored car sat exactly where the driver had parked it, ribbon still tied in the boot.

Vikram stood beside it for perhaps a minute.

Nobody watching him would have called what came over his face rage.

It looked, if anything, like arithmetic — a man solving one final sum before closing the book.

He picked up a fist-sized stone from the flowerbed lining the entrance.

Didn't swing it in fury.

Brought it down once, deliberately, on the windshield.

Then once more on the bonnet, denting the cream paint he'd chosen himself two weeks ago after looking at eleven color swatches with an attention to detail he never gave his own wardrobe.

He set the stone down on the driver's seat, almost politely, the way you'd return a book you'd borrowed.

Got into his own car.

Left the gift exactly where it stood — wrecked, ribboned, and paid for.

Ira came down forty minutes later, adjusting an earring, laughing at something Rajeev had said in the lift.

She stopped at the sight of the car.

Glass across the pavement, catching the streetlight.

The security guard, an older man named Naresh who had opened that gate for Vikram eleven times that year without ever learning his last name, stepped forward.

"Madam.

Vikram sir came.

Brought this car for you.

Left it there.

Then left in anger."

Ira said nothing for a long moment.

Rajeev, beside her, asked what everyone in that story except Vikram always asks too late.

"Did he see us?"

Nobody answered him.

Ira was still looking at the ribbon, soaked now from where the radiator had leaked out beneath the car overnight, still tied in a bow nobody would ever get to undo the way it was meant to be undone.

He never spoke her name again.

Not to Pradhan-babu, who never asked.

Not to Rohan, who heard a version of it third-hand years later and never brought it up.

Not, for a long time, to anyone.

The card was cancelled the next morning — a five-minute phone call, no note, no message.

Some silences are just silence.

Others are the loudest thing a man ever says.

PART 4

After Ira, Vikram stopped explaining his evenings to anyone.

Pradhan-babu noticed the office lights stayed on later.

Rohan noticed his brother stopped mentioning names at all, of any kind, the way a man stops walking near a particular pothole after he's twisted his ankle in it once.

Neither said anything.

Work absorbed what the evenings used to hold.

By thirty, the company's Odisha operations ran themselves well enough that Pradhan-babu, now nearing retirement in earnest, told anyone who asked that "Ahuja Sahib could run this with his eyes closed, which is a problem, because a man needs something to keep his eyes open for."

Nobody quite understood what he meant by that except Vikram.

The call came on a Tuesday, this time not from an uncle, but from the family doctor directly, in the flat, unhesitating tone doctors use only when there's nothing left to soften.

"Mr. Ahuja, I won't use words like 'let's see.'"

Your father's liver has failed past the point where 'let's see' means anything.

Weeks. Possibly a few months, if he's fortunate and careful."

Ten years since the last version of this phone call.

Ten years, and this time the sentence didn't leave any doors open.

Vikram sat with the phone still against his ear long after the doctor had disconnected, the dial tone humming the particular silence of a fact that has stopped being negotiable.

Binay insisted on the board meeting anyway.

"If I'm going, Vikram, I'm going having placed you in that chair myself.

Not leaving it for lawyers and vultures to argue over after."

The boardroom held twelve men that morning, the same long table Vikram had once sat beside as a teenager signing things Pradhan-babu told him to sign, except now three of the twelve stood up slightly straighter when he entered, and he'd stopped noticing exactly when that had started happening.

Binay sat at the head, thinner than the frailty of ten quiet years should account for — this was new, sharper, the kind of thin that has a deadline attached to it.

The agenda: South India expansion.

Two new states, three cities, an entirely different tax structure, a market that had ignored the Ahuja name for three generations because the Ahuja name had never once tried to enter it.

Sinha, silver-haired, the one who'd argued for Vikram's seat on this board a decade ago when nobody else had, spoke first.

"We need younger perspective for a market like this. Someone unafraid of an unfamiliar map."

Reddy, older still, arms folded, hadn't looked at Vikram once since the meeting began.

"South India needs experience.

Not a fresh graduate's confidence."

"He's run daily operations here for ten years," Sinha said.

"Here," Reddy said, finally turning to face Vikram directly, not unkindly, simply certain.

"Here, where the ground was already laid by his father, and every supplier already knew the Ahuja name before Vikram walked into a room.

South India will not extend him that courtesy.

Nobody down there has heard of us, and nobody down there owes us patience."

He looked at Vikram properly for the first time.

"What do you know about building something nobody is required to trust yet?"

The room waited.

*Vikram thought of a hostel corridor phone, a pathology textbook left unopened on a desk, a factory supervisor twisting his cap saying **sir** to a nineteen-year-old who didn't yet know how to sign his own name properly.*

He thought of eleven months fighting a liquor policy nobody else in that room had lost sleep over.

He thought of a stone, and a windshield, and how nobody in this room knew about that either.

Ten years of things nobody in this room had witnessed, and here was Reddy, entirely sincerely, asking what he knew about being unproven.

"Nothing," Vikram said finally. "I know nothing about it yet."

Reddy almost smiled, as if the honesty confirmed something.

"Exactly my point."

"But I know what it costs to become known somewhere new," Vikram continued. "I've paid that particular bill once already. I didn't enjoy it. I'd like the chance to pay it again, somewhere it might actually build something instead of just costing me something."

Nobody in the room understood the second sentence, and Vikram didn't explain it.

Reddy studied him a moment longer.

"Still," he said, not unkindly, "a kid taking on a grown man's risk."

Sinha bristled. "Every leader starts somewhere, Reddy."

"He didn't start today," Reddy said. "That's exactly my worry. He's been quietly competent in a market that forgives him. I don't know yet if he's competent in one that won't."

Binay, from the head of the table, raised one thin hand before the argument could widen.

"Meeting adjourned."

His voice cost him something to produce, audible in the shortness of breath after it.

"We resume tomorrow, once everyone in this room remembers we have less time than we think — some of us considerably less than others."

Chairs scraped back.

Twelve men filed out in the particular silence of people who've been quietly, individually reminded of their own mortality by someone else's.

Vikram remained seated, looking at the empty chairs, at Reddy's unfair-fair question still sitting in the air like smoke that hadn't found a window yet.

PART 5

The room emptied out slowly, the way rooms do when everyone in them is pretending not to hurry.

Vikram stood at the window after the last chair had scraped back, hands in his pockets, looking down at the city his father's name had built one clumsy signature at a time.

He didn't hear Binay come back in.

"They don't believe you can do it."

Vikram didn't turn.

"I've been doing it for ten years, and nobody in that room noticed."

Binay came to stand beside him, slower than he used to, one hand briefly finding the window frame for balance before he let go of it again, unwilling to be seen needing it.

"That's the wrong complaint."

"What's the right one?"

"The question was never whether they noticed."

A pause, long enough that Vikram finally looked at him.

"The question is whether you'll do it again. Somewhere nobody hands you the ground already prepared. Somewhere you're the kid Reddy thinks you are, because for one honest minute, you actually will be."

Vikram looked back at the glass.

The city lights outside had turned the window into a soft double exposure — the boardroom behind him faintly ghosted over the skyline in front, and somewhere in the overlap, for just a blink, the reflection looking back wasn't a thirty-year-old in a suit.

It was thinner. Younger. A hostel corridor phone still warm against one ear.

He blinked and it was gone, replaced by the version of himself that had learned, over ten patient years, exactly how much a face can be asked to hold without cracking.

"I did it once already," Vikram said, "when I didn't choose it."

"Yes."

"This time I'd be choosing it."

"Yes," Binay said again, and there was something almost like relief in the single word, the sound of a man setting down a question he'd been carrying longer than his son knew.

Neither of them said the rest of it out loud — that "choosing it" this time also meant choosing it without a father in the next room to call if it went wrong, that the ten remaining weeks or months were the last stretch of road where Vikram would ever again get to make a decision with Binay Ahuja still alive to see it land.

Vikram didn't answer with words.

He straightened his jacket, the way he had once straightened a borrowed apron in front of a bathroom mirror before a ragging that turned out to be nothing worth fearing, and found that the promise he was making wasn't really to Reddy, waiting to be proven wrong tomorrow.

It wasn't even to the thin man standing beside him, though he owed him more than either of them would ever say plainly.

It was to a nineteen-year-old who had once left a pathology textbook open on a hostel desk, mid-sentence, and never gotten to finish reading it.

I'll finish something, for you, he thought. Not that. But something.

"Tell them yes," Vikram said. "South India. All of it."

Binay nodded once, the nod of a man who'd expected this answer and was still glad to hear it out loud.

They stood together at the window a while longer, saying nothing else, the city going on beneath them exactly as it had before either of them decided anything at all.

PART 6

I didn't know any of this when it happened.

Vikram never told me the board meeting story, or the window, or Ira Sen's name, not once, not even later when we were old men and had run out of things to hide from each other.

I pieced it together the way you piece together most of a friend's life you weren't present for — from a line here, a name mentioned once and never again, a nurse's file, an old employee who still remembered "Ahuja Sahib" fondly enough to talk.

Some of it I'm still guessing at. I'll say so when I am.

What I do know, because he told me this part directly, once, sitting outside the ICU with two cold cups of tea neither of us drank:

"I never wanted the business, Adarsh. Twice life decided for me. Not once."

I asked what he meant by twice.

"1996. Then 2007. My father's liver, both times. First time it let go of him a little. Second time it didn't."

He didn't explain further, and I didn't ask him to. Some men tell you a fact and expect you to sit with it, not chase it.

I sat with it for years before I understood what he meant.

Two times, a decade apart, the same door opened and pulled him out of a life he'd actually chosen — a stethoscope, a hostel room, a friend, me — and put him behind a desk he hadn't asked for.

Most men would have called that unfair and stopped there.

Vikram didn't run either time.

I know that much for certain, because I watched what came after, even the parts I didn't understand until much later.

That was the board meeting.

That was the window.

That, I would learn only after his death, was also Ira Sen, whose name he mentioned to me exactly once in fifty years, and only in passing, as if checking that the wound was still there before moving on.

But that was only the beginning.

The real test came next.

CHAPTER III: THE BROWN CHAIR

PART 1

The company had no office in this state yet, only a name that meant nothing here and a folder of licenses waiting to be argued over.

So they'd put him up wherever the local team could arrange affordably, which turned out to be a farmhouse on a hillside outside town, half orchard, half nothing at all, jungle pressing close on the far edge of the coffee plants.

Vikram arrived alone except for a driver he'd already forgotten the name of, and a suitcase not made for these roads.

Ramanna kept the place — an old man with a torch that flickered more than it lit, a dhoti pressed into permanent wrinkles, and a habit of calling every guest "sir" in a tone that made the word sound like a question.

"Board members usually don't come themselves," Ramanna said, unlocking the one guest room. "They send juniors."

"I'm the junior," Vikram said.

Ramanna looked at him properly for the first time, decided something privately, and said nothing further about it.

The room smelled of the last rain, and the one before that.

Vikram lay listening to sounds a city never let him hear — some insect working continuously at nothing, a dog somewhere deciding against barking at the last moment, the particular creak old wood makes when it's simply cooling for the night.

Sleep didn't come easily anymore, not since Ira, not since board meetings started depending on which way one minister's mood tilted on a given morning.

He got up for water near midnight and saw the fire.

Not close. Past the coffee rows, at the edge where the plantation gave up and the jungle properly began, a small flame moved the way flames only move when someone keeps feeding them.

A figure sat beside it, motionless except for one arm rising and falling in some rhythm Vikram couldn't place from this distance — throwing something into the fire, or gathering something from it, he couldn't tell which.

He watched longer than he meant to.

At breakfast — curd rice, a pickle sharp enough to clear his head faster than the coffee did — Vikram asked Ramanna who lit fires past the plantation at night.

Ramanna didn't look up from the vessel he was scrubbing.

"Aghori Baba."

"Someone from the village?"

"From nowhere, sir. From the jungle. Comes some nights, not others. Nobody invited him, and nobody's told him to leave, so." Ramanna shrugged, a gesture that closed the subject more firmly than any sentence could have.

"What does he do out there?"

"Whatever Aghoris do." Ramanna finally looked up. "You want my advice, sir? Don't go and ask him. He'll tell you. That's the trouble with him. He always tells you."

Vikram laughed — the first time in longer than he could place exactly.

He didn't take the advice.

PART 2

The second night, Vikram went out to the fire.

He told himself it was for a walk, the way people tell themselves things when they've already decided otherwise.

The Aghori didn't look up as he approached, didn't stop the motion of his hand — ash, Vikram saw now, up close, a handful lifted and let fall through his fingers, over and over, into a fire that didn't seem to need any more fuel than that.

"Sit if you're going to sit," the Aghori said. "Standing there is worse manners than sitting."

Vikram sat, at a distance that felt safe and probably wasn't.

"You run something," the Aghori said. Not a question.

"A company. My father's."

"Your father's." The Aghori repeated it the way a man repeats a mistake back to someone, gently, so they can hear it themselves. "Whose is it now?"

Vikram didn't answer that.

The Aghori let another handful of ash fall.

"Everything you're building," he said, "this will be. Doesn't mean don't build it."

He came back the third night, and didn't need to be told to sit.

"What is that," Vikram asked, nodding at the ash.

"A body. Somebody's body, once. Doesn't matter whose." The Aghori said it the way other men discussed the weather. "You people are frightened of this. I sit in it. Sleep in it, some nights. It stops being frightening once you understand it isn't waiting for you specially. It's just where everyone ends up."

"That's a bleak way to live."

"Is it." The Aghori looked at him for the first time properly, eyes catching the firelight in a way that made Vikram look away first. "Or is it the only honest way to live, and everything else is just very good decoration around the same fact?"

Vikram had no answer for that either, and the Aghori didn't seem to expect one.

By the fourth day, the Aghori had started appearing at the farmhouse itself, in daylight, sitting on the low wall outside the guest room as if he'd always been permitted there, which perhaps, in Ramanna's silent accounting, he had.

Ramanna brought him tea without being asked, the way you'd bring tea to an uncle who visits too rarely to be told to stop.

"Empty," the Aghori said one afternoon, apropos of nothing, watching Vikram read a stack of licensing papers.

"What is?"

"All of it. This—" he gestured at the papers, the farmhouse, the hills, with the same hand, "—it will pass. You will pass. The company will pass. Even this tea will be finished in a minute, and no one will remember it was ever hot."

"Then why bother with any of it?"

"I didn't say don't bother." The Aghori drank his tea, unhurried. "I said don't be surprised when it goes. Different thing entirely. A man who expects the tea to go cold still drinks it while it's hot. Only a fool sits waiting for it to stay warm forever, and calls that patience."

Vikram found himself, oddly, finishing the papers faster that day, and minding it less.

He didn't tell Reddy, when they spoke on the phone that evening, why his voice sounded calmer than it had in months.

He wasn't sure he could have explained it correctly even if he'd tried.

PART 3

Ramanna asked him on the fifth morning, formally, standing straighter than Vikram had yet seen him stand.

"Sir. My daughter's marriage. Day after tomorrow. You are staying at my house. It would be my honour if you attend."

"I don't want to intrude on—"

"Intrude?" Ramanna looked genuinely wounded by the word. "You are staying under my roof. If you don't come, the whole village will ask what is wrong with my hospitality."

Vikram went.

The wedding took over the entire lane outside Ramanna's house — a pandal of bamboo and cloth thrown up in two days, banana stems tied to every pillar, mango leaves strung across the entrance in lines that dipped and rose like something breathing.

Somebody put a plate in his hands before he'd finished taking off his shoes.

"Eat, eat," said a woman he hadn't been introduced to, ladling a second helping of sambar onto his banana leaf before he could protest that he hadn't finished the first. "You've come from so far. You'll eat properly in this house."

He tried explaining he was only staying two days.

She didn't appear to hear that part.

By the second course he'd been fed by at least four different aunts, each one convinced the previous three hadn't fed him enough, and been informed by an uncle with a paan-stained smile that he looked "too thin for a business man, no offense," which Vikram found he didn't take as one.

The wedding itself happened in pieces he only half followed — the priest's Sanskrit running fast and rhythmic over the fire, Lakshmi in temple jewellery that looked too heavy for her thin wrists, her new husband's hands shaking slightly during the mangalsutra, a roar of conch shells and ululation that made Vikram's ears ring pleasantly for a full minute after.

Nobody asked him for anything.

Nobody wanted a licence signed, a policy explained, a board satisfied.

They wanted him to eat more, which he found, to his own surprise, he didn't mind at all.

On the second evening, sitting on Ramanna's veranda with his phone against his ear, he could hear the wedding band still going somewhere behind him.

"Sir, the minister's office confirmed Thursday," his assistant said. "Reddy sir will meet you there directly."

"Good."

"Also, sir — are you well? You sound different."

Vikram considered several ways of answering that were true.

"I've been eating a lot of sambar," he said finally.

His assistant, after a pause, decided not to ask further, which Vikram appreciated more than she probably knew.

Ramanna found him there after the call ended, two cups of over-sweet tea in hand, and settled onto the step without waiting to be invited, the way only a man who has decided you now belong a little to his house would.

"Good wedding?" Vikram asked.

"Good wedding," Ramanna agreed, then, after a moment, added the only compliment he seemed to consider worth giving. "You ate properly, at least. My wife was worried a big company man wouldn't eat village food."

"It was better than anything the company canteen serves."

Ramanna laughed — a short, surprised bark of a laugh, as if he hadn't expected to be believed.

They sat a while, saying nothing further, the band behind them working through the same four songs for the third time that night, neither man minding it in the least.

PART 4

Reddy was waiting outside the Secretariat gate when Vikram's car pulled up, standing in the shade of a neem tree with the particular stillness of a man who has waited outside enough government offices to have stopped minding it.

"You look well-rested," Reddy said, by way of greeting, sounding almost suspicious of the fact.

"Ramanna's wedding. His daughter's."

"Whose wedding?"

"Long story."

Reddy studied him a moment, decided not to pursue it, and turned toward the entrance instead. "Don't expect the same hospitality in here."

The Minister's outer office ran on its own private clock — twenty minutes became forty, forty became an hour, while a peon brought two rounds of tea nobody had asked for and a queue of other petitioners came and went ahead of them with the ease of people who'd learned exactly which palms needed greasing and which didn't.

"This is normal," Reddy said, not looking up from his files. "Don't take it personally."

"I'm not."

"You're checking your watch every four minutes."

Vikram stopped checking his watch.

Minister Satyanarayana, when they were finally shown in, turned out to be a small, unhurried man behind a very large desk, who gestured them to sit without getting up himself, and came to the point faster than the wait outside had suggested he would.

"Liquor," the Minister said, as if tasting the word and not much liking it. "You know what that word does to my file in this state?"

"I understand it's sensitive—"

"Sensitive." The Minister smiled without warmth. "My predecessor lost his seat over a liquor policy. Not because people stopped drinking. Because the opposition made him the man who let the poor man's family go hungry so he could drink. Doesn't matter if it's true. It only has to be sayable."

Reddy leaned forward. "Sir, with respect, the industry exists whether or not this company enters it. We're asking for land allocation for a compliant, licensed unit. Nothing about the moral question changes because of who holds the license."

"Everything about the moral question changes based on whose name is on the license, Reddy garu. You know this game as well as I do." The Minister looked at Vikram directly for the first time. "Your father's company. Big name. Big target, if anyone wants to make an example."

"So the land isn't available," Vikram said.

"I didn't say that." The Minister leaned back. "I said it isn't available easily. There's a difference, and the difference costs time, not just money."

Outside, back in the car, Reddy didn't bother softening it.

"This is what I meant, in the boardroom. This isn't home ground. Here, every 'no' has to be understood as maybe, and every 'maybe' has to be earned twice over, because nobody owes your name anything yet."

"I heard you the first time. In the boardroom."

"Hearing and understanding aren't the same thing," Reddy said, not unkindly. "I'll be honest, Vikram. I still don't know if this land comes through in a month or in three years. Could go either way. Could not go at all."

Vikram looked out the window at the Secretariat gate shrinking behind them.

"Then we wait," he said, "and we don't waste the waiting."

Reddy glanced at him sideways, as if that sentence hadn't sounded quite like the Vikram he'd expected on this trip, and said nothing about it, filing the observation away the way careful men file things they intend to bring up again later.

PART 5

He left on the sixth morning, the car already loaded, Ramanna hovering near the boot insisting on carrying a bag Vikram was perfectly capable of carrying himself.

The Aghori was waiting by the coffee rows, as if he'd known the exact morning without being told, which perhaps, in his own private accounting, he had.

"Going," the Aghori said. Not a question.

"For now. Land isn't settled. I'll be back and forth for months, maybe longer."

"Land is never really settled. Only borrowed for a while." The Aghori sat on the low wall, unhurried, the way he did everything. "Tell me something before you go. Why this? Liquor. Not medicine, not schools, not something a father could be simply proud of at dinner parties."

Vikram considered lying, the polished answer he gave boardrooms, and found he didn't want to give it here.

"It's not mine to choose," he said. "It was my father's. I never wanted it — not the company, not this business. Twice life put me in it anyway. I'm not chasing money. I stopped believing money was the point a long time ago. I just want to finish what he started, properly, because he can't anymore, and because some part of me still wants to prove I can."

"And the liquor part. Does that trouble you?"

"Yes." Vikram didn't soften it. "I know what it does to some houses. I've read the same reports the Minister's opposition will use against us. I'm not proud of the product. I'm proud, maybe, of doing it honestly where I can — the license clean, the tax paid, the workers looked after. It's not nothing. It's also not everything."

The Aghori looked at him for a long moment, the fire-catch in his eyes replaced now, in daylight, by something quieter.

Then he smiled.

He didn't explain the smile, and Vikram, who had learned by now not to ask, didn't request one.

"Here," the Aghori said instead, producing from somewhere in his ash-grey wrap a small folded paper, handed over without ceremony. "Sit like this in the morning, ten minutes, no more. And this word, repeat it when your mind runs too fast for you to catch it. Not for the liquor board. Not for your father. For you, when you're alone and nobody's watching and you still don't know who you're supposed to be that day."

Vikram unfolded it later, in the car, and found a simple seated posture sketched in a shaky hand, and beneath it, one word written twice, the second time underlined.

He didn't ask what it meant.

Some part of him suspected the not-asking was itself the point.

Ramanna knocked on the window as the car began to move, breathless from jogging alongside it the last few steps.

"Sir! Come again for the next wedding, whenever there is one!"

Vikram laughed, properly, and promised he would, and found — a little to his own surprise — that he meant it.

PART 6

The call came eleven days later, back at head office, in the middle of an unrelated meeting about tea packaging labels.

Vikram stepped out to take it.

"You won't believe this," Reddy said, and for once in his life sounded like he meant the phrase literally rather than as a figure of speech. "The MLA called Satyanarayana's office yesterday. Said to process the land allocation. No conditions."

"Why?"

"Nobody knows why. That's the part I don't believe. Man's been sitting on this file for two years, blocking it for reasons nobody could ever get straight, and now suddenly—" Reddy exhaled audibly down the line. "Doesn't matter. Take the win, Vikram. And it gets better. They've allotted double the acreage we asked for. Somebody upstairs must have decided to make it worth our while, or make up for lost time, or God knows what. I stopped trying to explain government logic years ago."

Vikram looked out through the glass wall of the corridor at the ordinary Tuesday traffic below, at people going about ordinary Tuesday errands with no idea that a two-year deadlock somewhere else had just, inexplicably, come undone.

"Vikram? You there? This is good news, in case that wasn't clear."

"I heard you, Reddy. It's good news."

"You don't sound like it's good news."

"I'm glad," Vikram said, and found, checking himself honestly, that he was — a clean, quiet gladness, without the fist-clenched triumph he might once have felt at the same news a year ago. "I just don't feel like I need to do anything about being glad. Does that make sense?"

"No," Reddy said. "But congratulations anyway."

That evening, alone in the hotel room he still hadn't gotten used to, Vikram found the folded paper again, in the inside pocket where he'd been carrying it without quite noticing he had.

He sat the way it showed, for the ten minutes it said, no more.

He didn't feel transformed. He didn't feel anything sudden or cinematic.

He felt, mostly, like a man who had stopped needing the outcome to arrive on time in order to keep doing the work anyway — which, he suspected, without being able to say exactly why, was the entire point of the exercise, and probably the entire point of the word he'd been given, still not fully understanding it, still not needing to.

Somewhere past the hotel's window, past the city, past several states, a fire was probably still burning at the edge of a coffee plantation, tended by a man who would likely never know what his ash and his silence had helped set in motion.

Vikram didn't call to tell him.

Some things, he was beginning to understand, weren't owed an explanation. Not even a grateful one.

He went back to his files that night lighter than he had in years, and the land, when it finally came through on paper three weeks later, felt less like a victory than like a fact he'd already made peace with in advance.

PART 7

The chair came with the office, which was really just two rooms above a spare-parts godown that the company had converted because nothing better was available yet in this city.

Brown leatherette, cracked along both arms, one wheel that stuck slightly and made the whole chair list two degrees left if you weren't careful standing up.

Vikram's second manager here, a sharp young man named Suresh, had tried twice to get it replaced.

"Sir, we can order a proper executive chair. Company budget allows for it easily."

"This one works."

"It's falling apart, sir."

"It hasn't fallen apart yet."

Suresh gave up after the second attempt, filing his boss under the general category of eccentric men he didn't need to understand to work for.

Vikram sat in it the night the first factory workers' wage dispute came to his desk — eleven men, three months unpaid because a regional distributor had defaulted and the company's own cash was tied up in the land deal that still hadn't cleared.

He could have waited. Legally, he had grounds to wait.

He sat in the cracked chair until past midnight going through the numbers twice, found a way to release partial payment from a different account by morning, and told Suresh to arrange it before the workers even arrived to ask.

"That's not how the process usually works, sir."

"I know."

"Head office will ask questions."

"Let them ask."

He sat in it again three weeks later, the night a second factory's water-supply request needed approval that would cost the company more than the state government would ever reimburse, and he approved it anyway, because the alternative was six hundred families carrying water two kilometers by hand indefinitely while paperwork moved through channels designed to move slowly.

"Why not just replace it," Reddy asked once, visiting the office and eyeing the chair with open disapproval. "It looks like something waiting to collapse."

"Because it doesn't let me forget."

"Forget what?"

Vikram didn't answer immediately, running one thumb along the cracked arm the way another man might touch a scar to check it was still there.

"Every time I sit in something comfortable, I start making comfortable decisions. This one reminds me every few minutes that it could give way. Keeps me honest about what's actually at stake when I sign something."

Reddy looked at him for a long moment, the way a man looks at someone he's revising an old opinion about.

He didn't say anything about it then.

He would, eventually — but that conversation belonged to a different night, a different pot of tea, still some weeks away.

For now, the chair held, listing its two degrees left, and Vikram kept signing what needed signing, one cracked-leather night at a time.

PART 8

Reddy came to the house himself this time, not summoned to any boardroom, holding a folder he kept patting like it might run away from him.

Binay received him in the small sitting room off his bedroom, the one with the good chair reserved for guests, thinner now than even the board meeting had shown, but alert, sharp-eyed, waving off the nurse hovering nearby.

"Binay saab." Reddy sat, opened the folder, then seemed to forget it entirely and just spoke. "Seven hundred crore. That's what the liquor business was doing when your son took over the South push. This year, it's crossed fourteen hundred."

Binay's eyebrows lifted slightly. That was the whole of his reaction, and it seemed to satisfy Reddy more than a speech would have.

"South alone," Reddy continued, "six hundred crore, manufactured there, exported worldwide now. Nobody thought a first-time entrant would touch international distribution this fast. We're already scouting land for two more plants. If this holds, we touch ten thousand crore within five years."

"You were the one who called him a kid," Binay said, not unkindly, watching Reddy's face carefully.

"I was." Reddy didn't look away from it. "I'll say it again if I'm ever wrong about someone else. I was wrong about this one."

Vikram stood near the window through all of it, saying little, the way he'd learned to stand through most rooms that discussed him rather than spoke to him.

When Reddy rose to leave, he crossed the room and rested a hand briefly on Vikram's shoulder — not a handshake, not a speech, just a hand, there and gone, the kind of gesture older men give when they've run out of better ways to say something.

Vikram felt something loosen in his chest that he hadn't realized was tight.

He stood at the window a while after Reddy's car had pulled away, watching the gate close behind it, and found the warmth of the moment fading faster than he expected it to.

Fourteen hundred crore. Ten thousand crore in five years. Numbers that would have meant everything to him once, in a hostel room, imagining a life entirely different from this one.

He didn't feel nothing. He felt, honestly, something closer to a duty discharged than a dream fulfilled — the particular flatness of doing a thing well that was never quite his to want in the first place.

Liquor had been his father's calling, not his. He'd carried it forward because someone had to, because the alternative was letting Binay's life's work collapse under a diagnosis nobody could argue with anymore.

*Somewhere underneath the fourteen hundred crore, a much smaller, much older thought kept surfacing, uninvited: **what would I have built, if I'd been building for myself instead of for him.***

He didn't know the answer yet.

He wasn't sure, standing at that window, that he was even supposed to be looking for one.

PART 9

The call came the next morning, before Vikram had finished his tea.

"Bhaiya." Meena's voice, Rohan's wife, tight and fast in the way voices get when they've been holding themselves together only for the length of a phone call. "Please. Don't panic. But Rohan's been arrested."

"Arrested. For what?"

"They're saying illegal transactions. Tender bypass. False documents — all false, bhaiya, I swear on our daughter, all false. He wouldn't sign off on the Nandyal plant construction. The contractor's work, the concrete mixing ratio, Rohan caught it himself, refused the certification. Yesterday the contractor's men came to the site office. Today the police came to our house."

Vikram sat very still, phone against his ear, cup cooling in front of him.

"He took that job on his own," Meena said, quieter now, almost apologetic, as if this fact embarrassed her on his behalf. "Wouldn't let me tell you he'd applied. Wanted to clear it without anyone knowing whose brother he was."

"I know."

"Please don't tell Papa. His heart — please, bhaiya, not right now."

"I won't. I'm coming."

The police station smelled of old paper and stale tea, a ceiling fan turning too slowly to matter, and Rohan sitting on a bench outside the lock-up with a swollen lip he wasn't quite hiding and wasn't quite showing either.

He looked up when Vikram walked in, and something in his face did several things at once before settling on none of them.

"You didn't need to come."

"Meena called me. Not you."

"I told her not to."

"I know that too."

The sub-inspector who'd been unhurried with Meena's earlier phone calls became, within four minutes of Vikram's lawyer arriving with the right papers and the right names attached to the right calls, a considerably more helpful version of himself — tea offered, chairs pulled out, an apology delivered in the specific tone reserved for men who fear they've made an expensive mistake.

Rohan watched all of it from the bench, silent, the swelling around his lip the only part of him that had moved in the last ten minutes.

He'd been on that same bench four hours earlier, before any lawyer, before any name attached itself usefully to anything — just an engineer who wouldn't sign a document, treated exactly like every other man who couldn't sign what a policeman was told to make him sign.

Nobody had offered him tea then.

In the car afterward, Rohan stared out the window without speaking for most of the drive.

"Thank you," he said finally, the words arriving stiff, like something handed over reluctantly because it was owed rather than felt.

"You'd have done the same."

"Would I." Rohan said it flatly, not quite a question. "I don't have a lawyer on retainer who makes inspectors pull out chairs, Vikram."

"That's not what I meant."

"I know what you meant." Rohan looked out the window again. "Doesn't change what I saw in there."

He didn't say what he'd seen, not directly, and Vikram didn't ask him to.

But something had shifted in the younger man's face somewhere between the bench and the car, something Vikram noticed and couldn't yet name, and Rohan, for his part, spent the rest of the drive making sure his brother never saw it clearly enough to try.

PART 10

The new plant at Nandyal sat on twelve acres of former cotton land.

The soil was still red, showing between the concrete foundations of the bottling unit like dried blood on concrete.

A chain-link fence ran all the way around, the top carrying three strands of galvanized barbed wire that caught the glare of the morning sun.

Vikram sat in his brown leatherette chair.

It was no longer above the spare-parts godown.

Suresh had moved it to the new administrative wing, a room that smelled of fresh paint, synthetic floor glue, and the air conditioning that hummed from a white box on the wall.

He had tried to leave the chair behind.

"It looks bad, sir," Suresh had said. "The visitors from the state capital — they sit on the new leather. Then they see this."

"The visitors don't pay the loaders' wages," Vikram said.

"Still, sir."

"Leave it," Vikram said.

So the chair had stayed. The wheel that listed two degrees left made a dark, curved streak on the new grey linoleum floor.

From his window, Vikram could see the loading bay.

Twelve multi-axle trucks were lined up in the dust, their engines idling, the grey smoke rising straight in the windless heat.

The loaders were mostly local boys from the villages near the hills.

They wore faded blue shirts with the company logo printed on the pocket — a simple black malt grain.

A boy of about eighteen was sitting on a wooden crate near the rear tyre of the third truck, eating curd rice from a steel tiffin box.

His hands were white with the dust of the cement packing.

He used his fingers to scoop the rice quickly, looking at the security gate every few seconds as if he expected someone to tell him to move.

Vikram watched him.

He remembered table seven in the dissection hall.

He remembered the smell of formaldehyde.

A student who had wanted to know the names of the muscles in the arm so he could heal them.

Now, he knew the names of the load-unions. He knew how many bags of barley a truck could carry before the highway police demanded a bribe.

The boy near the truck finished his rice, closed the steel box, and wiped his fingers on the side of the wooden crate.

He stood up, adjusted his blue shirt, and went back to the loading ramp.

The signature of Ahuja Sahib on the clearance ledger had given that boy a tiffin box and a faded blue shirt.

It was a good thing.

But as Vikram watched the truck move slowly toward the gate, the dust rising to cover the red cotton fields, he felt only the weight of it.

The fourteen hundred crore was a number on a page.

The twelve acres was a map in the register.

But the text in the ledger didn't say how many more boys would have to spend their afternoons in the red Nandyal dust to make the numbers match.

[End of Part 10]

PART 11

The telegram from Odisha was delivered to the Nandyal administrative office on a Tuesday afternoon.

It had only four words.

Binay serious. Come home.

Suresh had brought it in, his boots making a hurried, squeaking sound on the linoleum.

Vikram didn't read it twice.

He stood up from his brown leatherette chair.

"Pack the files, Suresh," he said.

"And the chair, sir? Should we send it by truck to the railway station?"

Vikram looked at the cracked armrest where the black tape had started peeling to show the grey foam inside.

"No," Vikram said.

"Leave it here. Let someone else sit in it."

He took his small leather bag, the same suitcase he'd brought five years ago, and walked out to the waiting car.

The Odisha house was silent.

Binay was in the upstairs bedroom, the one that looked out over the kitchen garden.

He was propped up on two flat pillows, his breathing shallow, the yellow jaundice showing deep in the whites of his eyes.

Rohan was sitting on the wooden stool near the window.

His shoes were clean today, but he had his hands in his pockets, his shoulders hunched as he watched Vikram enter.

He didn't stand up.

"You took your time," Rohan said.

"The train was delayed at Khurda," Vikram said.

He sat on the edge of the bed.

Binay's hand was dry and cold. The skin felt like loose parchment, the veins rising blue and stiff against the bone.

He opened his eyes slowly.

He looked at Vikram. Then at Rohan near the window.

"The Nandyal plant," Binay whispered.

"It is running, Papa," Vikram said. "The bottling unit is complete."

Binay nodded once, his eyelids closing again.

"Rohan," he said, his voice dry.

Rohan stood up, but he didn't come to the bed. He stayed near the cupboard.

"Yes, Papa."

"The company... it is yours now. Both of you."

Rohan looked at the floor.

"Vikram runs the board, Papa. I am just a site engineer."

Binay didn't answer.

He had already gone back to that quiet, unmoving state where the words of his sons didn't reach him.

Vikram stood up.

He walked to the window.

Rohan was looking at the kitchen garden where Ramu was collecting dry leaves in a basket.

"You should have stayed at the head office," Rohan said, his voice low. "Reddy says you did all the work in the South. He says the board only wants your signature."

"The signature is just ink, Rohan," Vikram said.

"It is not," Rohan said, turning his back.

"It is what decides whose name goes on the gate."

He walked out of the room.

His footsteps were loud on the wooden stairs, fading until only the slow, heavy breathing of their father remained in the room.

Vikram sat back on the edge of the bed.

He held the old man's hand.

The room smelled of barley water and the spirit the nurse used for the thermometer.

Outside, the sun was setting behind the kitchen garden, casting the shadow of the neem trees long and dark over the compost pit.

He knew this was the last week.

He knew the white coat was gone, and the company was all that remained.

But as he held his father's cold hand in the dark room, the fourteen hundred crore felt like nothing but a number written on a wall that was about to fall down.

[End of Chapter III]

CHAPTER IV: THE RED TEA

PART 1

The oxygen cylinder had a small brass regulator that leaked.

If you stood near the head of the bed, you could hear it.

A tiny, dry hiss.

Like steam escaping a pipe three rooms away.

Vikram had tried to tighten it twice with a spanner he'd borrowed from the driver.

Both times, the sound had stopped for ten minutes, then returned, slightly thinner but unchanged.

Binay Ahuja didn't seem to mind it.

Or perhaps he had simply stopped separating the sound of the room from the sound of his own breathing.

His skin had gone the grey-yellow of old newspaper left in the rain.

"Rohan didn't come today," Binay said.

His voice was barely louder than the regulator's hiss.

"He had site inspections at Nandyal, Papa."

"A site doesn't go anywhere, Vikram."

"There was a concrete issue. He wanted to check it himself."

Binay closed his eyes.

The saline line taped to his forearm was empty. A single bubble of air was trapped near the plastic lock, refusing to move up or down.

"He thinks I don't know," Binay whispered.

"Know what, Papa?"

"That he took that job because he didn't want to sit in your shadow here."

Vikram didn't answer.

He sat on the metal chair near the cupboard.

The room smelled of boiled barley water and the spirit the nurse used to clean the thermometer.

"Let him," Binay said, after a long silence. "It is better to build a small wall yourself than to live in a palace someone else gave you."

The phone call came at four in the morning.

It was the family doctor, Dr. Joshi.

He didn't use the words he usually used during his weekly visits.

*No **Portal pressure.***

*No **Let's see.***

He said: "Vikram. Come."

The house in Odisha had two gates.

*The main gate was wide, iron-grilled, with two stone pillars that had **Ahuja Villa** engraved in white marble.*

The side gate was small, green-painted, leading directly to the kitchen garden.

Vikram used the side gate.

The kitchen was already open. The old cook, Ramu, was sitting on a low wooden stool, cleaning cardamom pods in a brass plate.

He didn't look up when Vikram entered.

"Joshi saab is inside," Ramu said.

His fingers were slow, sorting the black seeds from the green husks.

"He asked for black coffee."

"Is Rohan here?"

"He arrived at three. He is in the study."

Vikram walked down the corridor.

The house felt larger than it had yesterday.

The lights were all on, but they seemed to illuminate only the corners of the rooms, leaving the furniture in a grey, unmoving shade.

Dr. Joshi was standing near the study door, his bag already zipped and placed on the corner table.

He looked at Vikram.

Nodded once.

"Heart stopped at three-forty," he said. "No pain. He simply ceased."

Vikram stood there.

He looked at the doctor's bag.

A black leather bag with a worn handle, the leather peeling near the lock to show the grey fabric underneath.

"Rohan is inside," Joshi said, touching Vikram's arm briefly as he passed. "Talk to him."

The study room was cold.

Binay's large teak wood desk was empty except for a brass paperweight shaped like a lion.

Rohan was sitting in the guest chair.

His shoes were covered in red Nandyal dust, a dry crust of it clinging to the welt of his left heel.

He didn't look at Vikram.

"You should have called me earlier," Rohan said.

"I called at midnight. Your phone was switched off."

"The site office has no network after ten. You know that."

"I sent the driver."

"The driver took three hours to reach," Rohan said. His voice was tight, thin, like a wire drawn too straight.

"He arrived after the doctor had already signed the certificate."

He stood up.

He walked to the window, looking out at the kitchen garden where Ramu was now throwing kitchen waste into the compost pit.

"Rohan," Vikram said.

"Don't," Rohan said. "Don't use that tone. The 'elder brother' tone."

He turned back.

His lip was still slightly dark near the corner where the contractor's men had hit him three months ago.

"Everyone at the site knew," Rohan said. "Before I did. The contractor's supervisor came to me at two. He said, 'Ahuja Sahib is serious, you should leave.' He said it like he was giving me a concession."

"He was trying to help."

"He was showing me that even my father's death is company business," Rohan said.

He walked to the desk, his finger tracing the brass lion's mane.

"Seven hundred crore. Fourteen hundred crore. Ten thousand crore. That's what you and Reddy talk about. That's what is written in the papers."

He looked at Vikram properly now.

"Papa died in this house. The house belongs to the company. The car Joshi came in belongs to the company. Even the shroud we will buy today will be billed to the office account."

"Rohan—"

"I don't want it," Rohan said. He spoke louder now, his voice echoing off the high ceiling. "I don't want your charity. I don't want to be the younger brother who was given a site-engineer job to keep him quiet."

"You chose that job yourself."

"Because it was the only one where nobody asked who my brother was!"

A silence followed.

The old ceiling fan in the study gave a low, metallic groan as it turned.

Rohan sat back down.

"He wanted a doctor," Rohan whispered. "He wanted you to wear the white coat. He told me that when I was twelve. 'Vicky will be the doctor.' He said it like I was just the spare."

"He didn't mean that."

"He did," Rohan said. "And then you left the college. You took the office. You took the board. You took the South expansion. You took everything he had to give."

He looked at his hands, at the red dust under his nails.

"And now he is gone."

Vikram didn't go to the office the next day.

Or the week after.

He stayed in the house, sitting in the small room off the kitchen.

Reddy came twice.

Sinha came once.

They sat in the drawing room, drank the tea Ramu brought, and talked about the transition.

"We need signatures, Vikram," Reddy said, on the second visit. "The Nandyal plant phase two needs approval. The banks are waiting."

"Ask Rohan to sign," Vikram said.

Reddy laughed. A short, dry sound.

"Rohan? He is an engineer, Vikram. The board won't accept his signature on a financial release."

"They will," Vikram said. "If he owns the shares."

Reddy stopped laughing.

He looked at Vikram's face.

"What are you saying?"

"Prepare the transfer documents," Vikram said. "The shares, the house, the Odisha license. Everything Binay Ahuja left. Transfer it to Rohan."

"You're out of your mind," Reddy said, standing up. "He can't run this. He doesn't know the distributors. He doesn't know the MLA."

"He will learn," Vikram said. "I learned."

The lawyer brought the papers on a Friday.

The study room was hot. Ramu had forgotten to turn on the cooler.

Rohan stood near the desk.

He didn't touch the pen.

"Why are you doing this?" Rohan asked.

"Because you want it," Vikram said.

"I didn't ask for a gift."

"It's not a gift," Vikram said. "It's what is yours."

He picked up the pen.

He signed first.

His signature had become neat over ten years, the letters even, the 'A' sharp and clear.

He kept the pen down.

"The driver is waiting outside," Vikram said. "The keys to the city office are on the table."

Rohan looked at the signed papers.

His hand trembled slightly as he picked up the pen to sign below Vikram's name.

He didn't look at his brother.

"Where will you go?"

"Sarita's place," Vikram said. "Near the bypass."

Rohan's pen stopped.

"The AIDS shelter?"

"Yes."

"People will talk, Vikram. They will say I pushed you out."

"Let them," Vikram said. "They have been talking since 1995. It is their business."

He picked up his small leather bag from the floor.

Two shirts.

One trousers.

Nothing else.

He walked out of the study.

He didn't use the main gate.

He walked through the kitchen, passed Ramu who was still sorting cardamoms, and went out of the green side gate.

The road outside was dusty, the afternoon sun direct and sharp.

He didn't call a cab.

He walked toward the bypass, his bag in his left hand, his face toward the heat.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

The Punarjeevan shelter had no gate keeper.

The rusted iron gate sat half-open, held in place by an old brick to keep it from swinging in the dust from the bypass road.

Vikram had walked four kilometers before the first truck driver offered him a lift on a flatbed carrying concrete pipes.

He had sat on the wooden bench of the driver's cabin, the smell of grease and raw diesel filling his lungs, saying nothing until the driver let him off near the bypass.

Sarita was sitting in the front courtyard under the shade of a drumstick tree.

She had a large plastic tub of red chillies in her lap, sorting the split ones from the whole.

Her saree was faded cotton, the color of wet brick.

She didn't look up when the gate creaked.

"We don't have visitor hours on Friday," she said.

"I am not a visitor," Vikram said.

She stopped sorting the chillies.

She looked at his leather bag. Then at his dusty shoes.

"Rohan signed?" she asked.

"He signed."

"And you?"

"I signed first."

Sarita went back to the chillies. A dry, rustling sound as she moved them.

"This is not a guesthouse, Mr. Ahuja."

"I know."

"We don't have clean sheets. We don't have separate rooms. The men sleep in the side hall. Six on the floor. One on the wooden bench."

"I can sleep on the floor," Vikram said.

She stood up, keeping the plastic tub on the stone ledge of the well.

Her hands were slightly red from the chilli dust.

"You're thirty-five," she said, looking him in the eye. "Same as me. You've sat in a leather chair for ten years. You think this is a retreat. A peace-finding exercise."

"No," Vikram said.

"It isn't. The municipal corporation cuts our water line twice a month because we don't pay the grease money. The local school refuses our kids. And three times a year, someone dies in the back room and we have to argue with the police to let us bury them without a post-mortem."

She wiped her hands on her saree.

"I have the virus, Vikram. I've had it for six years. My husband gave it to me before he died. Most people in this house have it. You don't."

"I know," Vikram said.

"Then why are you standing at my gate with two shirts?"

"Because nobody here calls me Ahuja Sahib," Vikram said.

Sarita studied his face for a long moment.

The wind from the bypass brought the dry smell of burnt rubber from the tire repair shops.

"Go to the well," she said finally. "Wash the dust off. Ramu's nephew brings the tea at five. It is cheap tea. We don't have sugar today, only jaggery."

The well water was cold.

Vikram drew a bucket, the hemp rope rough against his palms.

He washed his face, his neck, the dust of the Nandyal roads and the study room sliding off his skin.

A girl was standing near the drumstick tree, watching him.

She was thin, wearing a oversized blue frock that had a tear near the hem.

Her hair was tied in two tight plates.

She looked fourteen, perhaps fifteen. Her collarbones stood out sharp under the thin fabric.

"You are the factory man," she said.

"My name is Vikram."

"Sarita didi said you own the big trucks."

"My brother owns them now," Vikram said.

She came closer. Her eyes were large, dark, and had the specific, unblinking curiosity of a child who had grown up around adults who had stopped hiding things from her.

"I am Ananya," she said.

"Do you go to school, Ananya?"

"The school closed for me," she said, without sadness. "They said my blood is bad."

"Who said that?"

"The headmaster. He told Sarita didi that if I sit near the other girls, their parents will stop paying the fee. Sarita didi argued. She has a loud voice when she's angry. But the gate remained locked."

She looked at his leather bag near the well.

"What is inside?"

"Two shirts," Vikram said.

"No toys?"

"No."

"I have a wooden horse," she said proudly. "Ramu's nephew made it. It has only three legs, but it stands if you lean it against the wall."

Vikram smiled.

The first real smile since the doctor's phone call at four in the morning.

"Show me," he said.

They sat on the low stone wall of the well.

The wooden horse was small, carved from a branch of the drumstick tree.

Ananya leaned it against the bucket.

It stood.

"See?" she said. "It doesn't need the fourth leg. It is just for show."

Sarita came out carrying a steel kettle and three mismatched glasses.

She set them on the stone ledge.

The tea was dark red. No milk. The jaggery had turned it the color of boiled tamarind.

"Drink," she said.

Vikram held the glass.

The heat of the glass was direct, burning his fingers slightly.

He took a sip.

The jaggery was sweet, but the tea was strong, bitter at the edges.

Outside, the bypass traffic went on.

The trucks honked. The dust rose.

But inside the courtyard, the red tea tasted of nothing but the well water and the shade of the drumstick tree.

"It is good," Vikram said.

Sarita sat on the well wall beside Ananya.

She put her arm around the girl's shoulder, pulling her close.

"It is cheap," Sarita said. "But it is ours."

Vikram drank.

He looked at the three-legged horse, at Ananya's laughter as she knocked it down and set it up again, at Sarita's quiet face.

The fourteen hundred crore had gone to Nandyal.

The office keys were on the teak wood desk.

But the red tea in his glass smelled better than any tea he had ever had in a boardroom.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The shelter ran on a different kind of math.

In the head office, Vikram had watched ledger entries balance down to the paisa.

Here, a sack of potatoes was expected to stretch for nine days, but occasionally stretched for eleven because Ramu's nephew brought three heads of cauliflower that had gone slightly soft at the edges.

Vikram's job was the water.

Every morning at five, before the trucks on the bypass started their high-pitch honking, he drew twelve buckets from the well.

The first six went to the kitchen.

The next four to the wash area behind the drums.

The last two he kept near the drumstick trees for the children.

His hands, which had gone soft from ten years of holding executive pens, grew a thin layer of yellow calluses along the base of the fingers.

"You're drawing too fast," Sarita told him one morning.

She was sitting on the steps of the verandah, using a piece of broken glass to scrape the dirt off a pair of old rubber sandals.

"The rope will slip," she said.

"The rope is new," Vikram said.

"Ropes don't care if they are new, Vikram. They slip when they are tired."

She went back to the sandals.

She looked tired herself. Her cheeks had gone slightly hollow over the last two weeks, her eyes carrying the grey shadow that came when the medicine from the government hospital didn't suit her stomach.

She never mentioned it.

But Vikram had started noticing the exact hour she went to her room to lie down.

It was always three in the afternoon, when the heat of the tiled roof was the worst.

Ananya sat on the well wall, her legs swinging over the side.

She was holding a notebook Vikram had bought from the bypass store.

"What is this word?" she asked, pointing her pencil.

***"Equation,"** Vikram said.*

"What does it mean?"

"It means two sides have to be equal. What you put on the left must match what is on the right."

She thought for a moment, her pencil tip touching her lip.

"Like a balance scale?"

"Yes."

"But if you put something on one side, and the other side has nothing, what happens?"

"It tilts," Vikram said.

"Then it is not an equation."

"No."

She closed the notebook.

"The school had a big black board," she said. "The teacher had three colors of chalk. Yellow, pink, and white. She only used the pink one when someone got the answer wrong."

"Which color did she use for you?"

"White," Ananya said. "I didn't get answers wrong. I just had the bad blood."

She hopped off the wall.

"Let's make the tea. Ramu's nephew brought the ginger today."

The tea stall near the bypass was run by a man named Shankar.

He had one wooden bench that sat in the shade of a hoarding advertising cement.

Vikram and Ananya walked there in the evenings.

Not because the shelter tea wasn't enough.

Because Shankar's stall was the only place where the truck drivers and the local laborers sat together without asking who had what.

They sat on the wooden bench, their backs to the cement ad.

Shankar served the tea in small glass tumblers.

Red tea.

Strong, sweet with local jaggery, smelling of the dry mud of the roadside and the diesel exhaust of the passing carriers.

"Your brother came to the factory yesterday," Shankar said, wiping a glass with a dirty rag.

Vikram looked at the road.

A multi-axle truck carrying iron ore was moving slow, its gears groaning under the weight.

"Reddy garu was with him," Shankar continued. "They had three cars. The big white one."

"Rohan likes the white one," Vikram said.

"People say he is very strict. He fined two loaders for being ten minutes late."

Vikram took a sip of his tea.

The jaggery was burnt at the bottom, leaving a bitter, sweet crust on the glass.

Ananya was watching a puppy near the tire shop.

"Let him be strict," Vikram said. "A new house needs a strong door."

"But you," Shankar said, looking at Vikram's faded cotton shirt. "You were the Ahuja saab. People used to stand up when your car passed the crossing."

"They still stand," Vikram said. "To cross the road."

Shankar laughed.

He didn't ask further.

They walked back as the sun was setting behind the bypass hills.

The sky had gone the color of a bruised plum.

Ananya was walking ahead, balancing herself on the concrete edge of the drain.

"Vikram," she called.

"Yes."

"When the school starts again, will you teach me the pink chalk words?"

"Yes," Vikram said.

"Even the ones that are wrong?"

"Especially those."

She smiled, her plates swinging as she ran a few steps ahead.

At the shelter gate, the brick was still holding the iron grill open.

The smell of Ramu's nephew's wood fire was coming from the kitchen — dry wood, slightly damp from the evening dew, mixing with the smell of the red tea they had left behind at the bypass.

Vikram stood near the gate.

He looked at his hands.

The calluses were rough. The nails had grey dirt under them that didn't go away with well water.

But his chest felt light.

Like the air bubble trapped in the saline tube, he had finally found the lock, and it had opened.

He walked inside.

The red tea was waiting.

[End of Part 3]

CHAPTER V: THE YELLOW ENVELOPE

PART 1

*The bulldozer was yellow, with a dented steel bucket that had **Escorts** painted in red letters on the side.*

It sat near the shelter gate for three days before it started working.

The driver spent the first two days sleeping in the cabin, his legs dangling out of the open door, his shirt thrown over the steering wheel to block the sun.

On the third morning, the municipal junior engineer arrived in a jeep.

He didn't get down.

He simply waved a blue paper toward Sarita, who was standing near the well holding a plastic bucket.

"Road widening," he shouted over the jeep's engine. "Clear the rooms by twelve."

"We have fourteen patients," Sarita said. "Three cannot walk."

"The order was signed in March, sister. The contractor is paying daily rent on the machine. Twelve o'clock."

He turned the jeep.

The dust from the tyres settled on the drumstick trees, turning the green leaves a dull grey.

Vikram had tried to call Rohan from the post office phone.

He had dialled the office number twice.

Both times, the receptionist's voice had come through the static, polite and unyielding.

"Ahuja saab is in a board meeting. Leave a message."

"Tell him it's Vikram."

"Yes, sir. I have noted it."

He didn't call again.

At eleven-thirty, the steel bucket of the bulldozer touched the courtyard wall.

A low, grating sound of mortar giving way.

Ananya stood near the kitchen door, holding her wooden horse and the notebook with the white chalk drawings.

She wasn't crying.

She looked at the machine with the same unblinking curiosity she had used for the equations.

"It is very loud," she said.

"Yes," Vikram said.

"Will they break the well too?"

"Yes."

She nodded.

She walked to his side, her small hand finding the pocket of his faded cotton shirt, holding onto the fabric.

"Where will we sleep tonight?"

"Kolkata," Vikram said.

The train was the Howrah Express.

They had three third-class compartments, the tickets bought with the last eight thousand rupees Sarita had in the shelter tin box.

The patients sat near the windows, their thin faces drawing the attention of the vendors selling tea and peanuts at every station.

An old woman with a severe cough kept her face covered with her saree border.

A passenger from the middle berth looked down, saw her thin wrists, and moved his luggage to the upper rack.

He didn't say anything.

Neither did Sarita.

She sat opposite Vikram, her forehead pressed against the iron bars of the window.

The fever had returned.

Her skin was hot to the touch, dry and paper-thin.

"The house belongs to my husband's uncle," she said. Her voice was thin, dry like the breeze outside. "He died in ninety-two. The sons went to Delhi. Nobody has lived there for twenty years."

"Is there a well?" Vikram asked.

"A municipal tap," she said. "In the courtyard. And three big neem trees. The leaves are good for the heat."

She closed her eyes.

"It is in Bagbazar. Near the river. The wind smells of wet jute and river mud."

Vikram looked at the passing fields.

The green paddy of Odisha was slowly giving way to the grey marshlands of Bengal.

The wheels of the train kept up their rhythmic, metallic clank.

Fourteen hundred.

Fourteen hundred.

Fourteen hundred.

The number didn't have the same sound anymore.

It was just noise.

The house in Bagbazar had a large wooden door that had swollen from the monsoon damp, refusing to open more than a foot.

Vikram had to shoulder it twice, the old iron lock cracking inside the wood with a sound like dry bone breaking.

The air inside was thick, smelling of bat droppings, wet lime, and the cold, unventilated damp of twenty years of shadow.

The plaster had fallen off the walls in large, curved sheets, showing the thin red brick underneath.

A courtyard sat in the middle, three neem trees growing wild, their roots lifting the old stone tiles at angles.

*An old marble nameplate near the entrance read: **Sen family. 1924.***

Ananya walked in first, her sandals making clean prints in the thick grey dust that covered the floor.

"It has many rooms," she said.

"Eleven," Sarita said, leaning against the door frame to catch her breath.

She looked at the courtyard, at the dry neem leaves that had piled up in the corners.

"The tap is in the corner," she said, pointing to a rusted iron pipe rising from the stone.

Vikram went to the tap.

He turned the handle.

A dry squeak. Then a thin stream of orange, rust-stained water came out, sputtering before it went clear and cold.

He drew a handful.

It tasted of iron and river sand.

He washed his face.

The water felt different from the Odisha well.

It was heavier. Older.

Sarita sat on the lowest step of the verandah, her head resting against the wooden pillar that had been eaten away by termites near the base.

"We will start with the front room," she said. "Sweep the dust. The patients are waiting at the crossing with the luggage."

Vikram picked up a broom he'd bought at the station.

The bamboo bristles were stiff, scratching the old stone floor with a sharp, dry sound.

Ananya sat near the well tap, setting her three-legged horse on a clean stone she'd wiped with her skirt.

It stood.

"See?" she said, pointing. "It works here too."

Vikram began to sweep.

The dust rose in the afternoon sun, turning the shafts of light into columns of moving, grey sand.

He swept the first room.

Then the second.

His hands, already hard from the well rope of Odisha, didn't feel the bamboo handle anymore.

He had left the boardrooms.

He had left the big white cars.

He had left the name that opened gates.

But as he swept the dust of twenty years out of the Sen family house, the iron-tasting water of the Bagbazar tap felt like exactly enough to keep him where he was.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

By the winter of 2015, the name Punarjeevan was painted on the main wooden door in clean Bengali script.

The wood had stopped swelling.

Vikram had planed the edges himself, using a small steel block plane he'd bought from a hardware market in Shobhabazar.

The house had become clean, the bat droppings swept away, the courtyard tiles reset.

They had twenty-two beds now.

Sarita's fever came less often, but she had started using a walking stick. A simple bamboo cane, identical to the one Vikram had left in Odisha, except this one had no red cloth at the top.

Ananya was seventeen.

She had grown tall, her hair no longer in plates, but tied in a single ponytail with a thick rubber band.

She spent her mornings at the register table near the door, writing patient entries in a ledger that had a green cloth cover.

Her handwriting had become neat, the letters upright and small, just like the notes Vikram had written for her.

The courier arrived at twelve.

He didn't walk inside.

He stood at the threshold, his bicycle leaning against the wall, holding a yellow envelope.

"Vikram Ahuja?"

Vikram, who was clearing dead neem leaves from the courtyard drain, stood up.

"Yes."

"Registered post. From Cuttack. Forwarded from Bhubaneswar."

The postmarks on the yellow paper were overlapping, three circles of purple ink, one of them showing the date: 12-10-15.

Vikram signed the slip.

The paper was cheap, rough to the touch, the yellow color slightly faded at the corners where the glue had dried.

He sat on the lowest step of the verandah.

Sarita was in the kitchen, the smell of boiling rice and cumin coming through the open window.

He tore the top of the envelope.

The letter was written on two sheets of ruled paper.

The handwriting was small, the letters rounded, with the specific, careful spacing he had seen on drafts of news articles ten years ago.

Vikram,

I don't know if this address will find you. I asked Rohan's office three times before a clerk took pity on me and wrote the Kolkata post box number on a slip.

I am not writing to ask for forgiveness. Some things don't have a balance sheet.

After Odisha, Rajeev married me. He insisted on conversion. I did it because I had lost the paper job and had no other room to go to. He changed my name to Ummed.

It lasted four years.

The abuse was not loud. It was daily. He took the cards. He took the bank account. When our son was born, he said the child would have only one name, his.

Rehman.

Three years ago, Rajeev left. He went to Hyderabad with another reporter. He didn't leave a number or an address.

I raised Rehman alone. I work at a local press in Cuttack, proofreading municipal directories. It pays enough for the room and the rice, but nothing else.

Rehman is nineteen now. He has finished his intermediate. He doesn't want to work at the press. He wants to do service work. He wants to help people who have nothing.

I told him about you. Not the tycoon. The Vikram who walked away.

He wants to learn from you. He wants to work at your shelter.

If you can take him, guide him, it will give me some peace. A small payment against the debt I owe you.

He will arrive tomorrow. He has the Howrah passenger ticket.

Ira.

Vikram sat there.

The neem leaves in the courtyard moved slightly in the wind, a dry, whispering sound against the stone.

Ummed.

The name was new, yet it had the cold weight of the transaction alert on his phone from Salt Lake.

Rs. 340 debited.

He looked at the yellow envelope.

The paper was cheap, the kind sold at railway station stalls for ten paise.

"Who was it?" Sarita asked, coming out of the kitchen with a plate of sliced cucumbers.

She sat on the step beside him.

"A letter," Vikram said.

"From Odisha?"

"From Ira."

Sarita didn't ask who Ira was.

Some names don't need a designation when you have lived with a man's silence for three years.

"What does she want?"

"Her son is coming tomorrow," Vikram said. "He wants to work here."

Sarita picked up a slice of cucumber.

"We have room," she said, looking at the courtyard well. "We always have room for someone who has nowhere else to go."

Vikram folded the paper.

He put it back into the yellow envelope.

The postmark was still purple, dry and clear under the grey light of the Bagbazar sky.

He kept it in his shirt pocket.

The cheap paper felt thin against his chest, but as he stood up to return to the drain, it had the weight of a stone that had finally found its well.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The boy arrived at three in the afternoon, when the shadows of the neem trees had stretched across the courtyard well.

He was carrying a blue canvas bag with a rusted zip that didn't go all the way to the end.

His shoes were cheap black canvas, the soles worn thin, a line of grey station dust outlining the toes.

He stood near the swollen wooden door.

He didn't knock.

*He simply stood, his hands holding the straps of the bag, looking at the nameplate **Sen family** with the quiet concentration of a passenger checking a ticket.*

Ananya saw him first from her table.

She stood up, holding her pen.

"You are Rehman?"

The boy nodded. He had a slight Odia accent in his voice.

"My mother sent me," he said.

Vikram came out of the back room, carrying a bucket of lime wash he'd been using to repair the kitchen wall.

His hands were white with the wash, a splash of it dried near his left temple.

He set the bucket down.

The boy saw him.

He didn't fold his hands immediately. He looked at Vikram's face, his eyes moving slowly from the white splash on the temple to the faded shirt, then down to his calloused hands.

Then he bowed, his hands folding near his chest.

"Vikram uncle?"

"Yes," Vikram said.

"I am Rehman."

Vikram looked at the boy's eyes.

They were large, dark, the shape of the lids identical to the ones that had watched him fact-check quotes in the Salt Lake office ten years ago.

But they had none of her restlessness. They were still.

"Your train was on time?" Vikram asked.

"Two hours late at Howrah," the boy said. "I took the bus to Bagbazar crossing. The conductor showed the lane."

Sarita came out, leaning on her bamboo cane.

She looked at the canvas bag.

"Have you eaten?"

"No, didi," the boy said.

"Ramu's nephew is in the kitchen. Tell him to give the dal. The rice is cold, but it works."

She looked at Vikram.

"He can sleep in the corner of the side hall. Ramesh's old bed is empty since he went to the hospital."

Rehman looked at the courtyard tap.

"I will wash the face first," he said.

He washed at the tap.

He drew the water with one hand, his canvas bag kept carefully on the stone ledge near Ananya's table.

Vikram watched him from the verandah.

The boy's neck was thin, the vertebrae standing out under the collar of his faded blue shirt as he bent over the tap.

He washed twice, using a small piece of red soap he'd brought from his bag.

It was the cheap, local soap sold at Cuttack shops.

He wiped his face with a small green towel.

"Where is the work, uncle?" he asked, coming back to the steps.

"The work is everywhere," Vikram said. "Today, we are whitewashing the kitchen. Tomorrow, the medicine delivery arrives."

"I can do the whitewash," the boy said.

He picked up the spare brush near the bucket.

He didn't ask how to hold it. He didn't ask where to start.

He simply went to the kitchen door, looked at the grey patch on the wall where the plaster had been repaired, and began to paint.

His strokes were slow, slightly uneven, but he didn't stop until the grey was covered in clean, flat white.

Vikram stood beside him.

He took the second brush.

For one hour, they painted the wall together, the smell of fresh lime and damp brick rising between them in the small kitchen.

Outside, the afternoon faded.

The shadow of the neem trees covered the well.

Ananya sat at her table, her pen moving regularly as she entered the evening medicines in the green cloth ledger.

At five, Ramu's nephew brought the kettle.

Red tea.

Shankar's jaggery had gone, but Sarita had bought a small cone of palm sugar from the market.

They sat on the verandah steps.

Three mismatched glasses.

"It is good tea," Rehman said, blowing on the hot glass.

"It is cheap," Sarita said, sitting near Ananya. "But it keeps us warm."

The boy drank.

He looked at the neem trees, at the old marble nameplate, at the white wall he had painted.

"My mother told me," Rehman said, his voice quiet. "She said you were a tycoon once."

Vikram looked at his glass.

The red tea was hot, the palm sugar sweet and dark.

"She was mistaken," Vikram said.

"I was never a tycoon."

The boy smiled.

A small, quiet smile that had nothing of the boardroom in it, and nothing of Cuttack.

"I know," Rehman said.

"The tycoon would never have painted the kitchen."

Vikram drank his tea.

The Bagbazar tap water was heavy, but the red tea tasted of the fresh lime on his brush and the neem leaves in the wind.

He looked at the yellow envelope sitting on the study table inside.

The envelope was closed.

The boy was here.

And as the night settled over the Sen family house, the red tea in his hand was the ultimate thing.

[End of Part 3]

CHAPTER VI: THE GREEN LAWN

PART 1

The park bench was made of iron slats painted green.

The paint had blistered from the Kolkata heat, peeling away in long, curved strips that looked like dried snake skins on the grass.

It sat in the middle of Bagbazar park, under a large banyan tree whose aerial roots had grown down to touch the ground, enclosing the bench on three sides like a wooden cage.

Vikram sat there in the mornings.

He had started sitting there after Sarita left for Delhi.

She had taken five patients with her, the ones who had recovered enough to help her set up the new shelter home near the Delhi airport.

"Rehman will handle Bagbazar," she had told Vikram before she boarded the train. "He has the ledger in his head, Vikram. He knows which distributor is late and which tap is leaking."

"I am here," Vikram had said.

"You are here physically," she said, leaning on her cane. "But your mind is still sweeping the dust. Let the boy do the numbers. He likes them."

He did.

Rehman brought the register to the park bench at eleven.

He sat on the iron slats beside Vikram, his blue canvas bag kept between his feet.

He was twenty-two now.

His shoulders had gone wider, his jaw carrying the sharp, dry line of an adult who spent more time talking to bank managers than to patients.

He wore a clean, white khadi kurta, but his shoes were still the same cheap canvas, now grey with Kolkata mud.

"The donations are not enough, uncle," Rehman said.

"They are enough for the dal," Vikram said.

"But not for the medicine. The government supply is late. The local supplier wants twelve percent interest on the credit. I told him he is a thief. He said the bank doesn't accept moral arguments."

He closed the register.

The green cloth cover had gone dark near the edges from where his palms had rested.

"We need a brand," Rehman said.

"A brand is for businesses, Rehman."

"If we have to beg for every rupee of medicine, we are not helping, uncle. We are just waiting for rich men to feel guilty on their birthdays and write cheques."

"What would you do?"

"Make our own things," Rehman said, his voice rising slightly. "The patients here have hands. They can pack medical kits. They can make incense from the temple flowers Ramu's nephew brings. Simple things."

He leaned forward, his elbows on his knees, looking at Vikram.

"Greed is bad, uncle. My mother taught me that. But **need** is not bad. If we have to buy paracetamol, we need money. If we have to fight the municipal clerks, we need power. Why should the devils have all the money and do what they want, while we stay small and sweep the dust?"

Vikram looked at the banyan roots.

A row of red ants was moving along a split in the bark, carrying a single grain of sugar.

"Power is a heavy thing, Rehman," Vikram said.

"It is only heavy when you carry it alone," the boy said. "We will carry it together. The patients will make the incense. I will sell it to the distributors."

He stood up.

"I have already decided the name."

"What name?"

"Ummed," Rehman said. "It means hope."

Vikram's hand stopped on the iron slat of the bench.

Ummed.

The name had the soft, Urdu sound of a letter written on ruled paper from Cuttack.

He changed my name to Ummed.

He looked at Rehman.

The boy was looking at the banyan leaves, his face clear, his smile open and free of the Odisha dust.

"It is my mother's name," Rehman said. "She told me once that when everything is lost, only Ummed remains."

"It is a Muslim name," Vikram said.

"She converted," the boy said, without looking back. "But the meaning didn't change."

He picked up his canvas bag.

"I will print the first labels today. Simple yellow paper. Like the envelope my mother sent."

He walked away down the gravel path of the park.

Vikram sat on the bench.

*The green paint felt hot under his fingers, but the name **Ummed** was still sitting on the grass between the banyan roots.*

Unmoving.

Growing.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

By 2022, the Ummed brand had moved from yellow paper labels to printed cardboard boxes.

The incense sticks were sold in three states, the medical kits distributed to ninety-two municipal health centers, the sanitary pads manufactured in three separate units near Barasat.

The business papers wrote the numbers.

Seventy-six hundred crore.

Vikram didn't read the papers.

He still slept in the side room of the Bagbazar house, on the same wooden bench he'd claimed when they arrived.

His clothes were still three faded cotton shirts, washed every morning at the courtyard tap.

Rehman had moved out.

He had rented an apartment in Alipore, with a security guard at the gate and a silver sedan that was cleaned twice a day by a boy he paid five hundred rupees a month.

He had been to Geneva twice for NGO conferences.

His white kurtas were silk now, the canvas shoes replaced by black leather loafers that had no mud on the soles.

"You should come to the Alipore house, uncle," Rehman had told him once. "It has air conditioning. The summer is bad for your lungs."

"My lungs are used to the neem leaves," Vikram said.

The celebration party was held in the lawn of a heritage hotel near the river.

Sarita had returned from New York.

She had successfully set up the US fundraising branch, Punarjeevan International, which had raised six million dollars in its first quarter.

The lawn was lit with small yellow bulbs hung from the mango trees.

Seventy people.

Three local MLAs.

Two bank directors.

A group of journalists from the business desks.

Sarita sat in a cane armchair near the food table, her walking stick leaning against her knee.

She looked thinner, but her eyes were bright.

"The numbers are huge, Vikram," she said, as he stood beside her.

"Yes," Vikram said.

"Rehman did it. He worked eighteen hours a day when I was in New York. He didn't sleep for a week during the Barasat license crisis."

"I know," Vikram said.

A local MLA approached, holding a glass of apple juice.

"Ahuja saab," he said, bowing slightly to Vikram. "Congratulations. What a massive vision. From Odisha to this. Only an Ahuja could have built a service empire this large."

Vikram didn't correct him.

He had tried correcting people for five years.

*They simply smiled, nodded, and went on writing **Ahuja** in the reports anyway.*

Rehman was standing three feet away, talking to a bank manager.

His glass was whiskey, the ice cubes clicking against the crystal.

He had heard the MLA.

He didn't turn.

But his shoulders went rigid under his silk kurta, his hand tightening around the glass until his knuckles went white.

The terrace of the hotel was dark.

Vikram had gone up to escape the noise of the catering staff cleaning plates.

The river Hooghly was visible between the warehouses, the water black, reflecting the yellow lamps of the Howrah bridge.

Rehman's footsteps were heavy on the brick floor of the terrace.

He was carrying his whiskey glass. It was empty.

"They only see you," Rehman said.

His voice was thick. The smell of alcohol was strong, mixing with the damp smell of river mud.

"Rehman," Vikram said.

"No," the boy said, walking closer. "Don't say it. Don't say 'it doesn't matter.' It matters to me."

He looked at the river.

"I did the licenses. I did the banking. I did the travel. I lived in hotels that smelled of insecticide for three years to set up the Barasat factory."

He turned to Vikram.

His face was red in the light from the bridge, his eyes wet.

*"And the MLA comes and says: **Only an Ahuja could do this.** What is an Ahuja? A name? A legacy? Because your father was rich?"*

"He didn't know," Vikram said.

"Nobody knows!" Rehman shouted. His glass slipped from his fingers, hitting the brick floor and cracking with a sharp, dry sound. "I am the candle, uncle. I burn myself to give the light. And everyone turns their face to the sun."

He walked to the edge of the terrace, his hands gripping the iron railing.

"Is it because of my name? Because I am Rehman? Because my mother converted? Because we had no house in Odisha?"

Vikram stood behind him.

"You built it, Rehman. The board knows. Sarita knows."

"But the world doesn't," the boy said, his voice dropping to a whisper. "I wanted to show them. I wanted to show my mother that I am not the spare. That I can build something bigger than what Rajeev took from us."

He looked back at Vikram.

"But I can't. Not as long as you are standing in the door."

He walked past Vikram.

His loafers made a sharp, clean sound on the brick floor.

"I am going to Alipore," he said, without looking back.

Vikram stood alone on the terrace.

The broken glass of Rehman's whiskey cup was catching the light of the bridge.

The wind from the river was cold.

But as he looked at the dark water, the fourteen hundred crore and the seventy-six hundred crore felt like the same thing.

A weight he was still carrying, even when he had nothing left in his pockets.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The lawyer's name was Bannerjee.

He had a small office in Dalhousie Square that smelled of red tape and damp sheepskin folders.

He arrived at Bagbazar on a Saturday morning, his black leather briefcase bulging with three copies of the transfer deed.

"This is the second time, Vikram babu," Bannerjee said, setting the papers on the register table.

Ananya was standing near the well, holding a broom.

She had stopped sweeping.

She was looking at the white paper documents, her eyes moving from the lawyer's clean cuffs to Vikram's hand.

"The second time is easier," Vikram said.

"It is never easier," Bannerjee said. "The first time, it was family. Your brother. This time, it is an employee. A boy who has been here four years. The board will ask questions. The international donors will want to know why the founder is walking away."

"The founder is tired," Vikram said.

He signed.

His signature didn't have the sharp 'A' it had in Odisha.

It was looser. The ink from the ballpoint pen had run slightly at the edge of the 'V', leaving a small blue blur on the bond paper.

Ramu's nephew brought the tea.

Mismatched glasses.

Red tea, but today the palm sugar was missing. It was just ginger and water.

Bannerjee drank his quickly, packed the signed deeds into his leather bag, and stood up.

"Rehman has the power now," the lawyer said. "The banking, the Barasat unit, the international funds. He is the CEO."

"Good," Vikram said.

Vikram fell sick three days later.

It was the winter cough, the cold from the Hooghly river settling in his chest, making every breath sound like the dry regulator hiss.

He stayed on his wooden bench in the side room.

Sarita brought him hot barley water twice a day.

"Rehman hasn't come," she said on the fourth morning.

"He is busy with the Barasat audit," Vikram said.

"He is in Alipore, Vikram. The supervisor said the silver sedan was parked outside the office for three hours yesterday. He didn't come up."

"Let him be," Vikram said. "The new shoes take time to fit."

The phone near the register table rang at seven that evening.

Vikram was alone in the room.

He walked out, his legs slightly stiff from the fever, and picked up the receiver.

"Uncle."

It was Rehman's voice.

It was quiet. The thick, drunk anger of the terrace had gone, replaced by a dry, hollow rattle.

"Rehman," Vikram said. "Where are you?"

"I am in Alipore."

"Come to Bagbazar. The lawyer has sent the deeds."

A long silence down the line.

The sound of city traffic, distant and light, came through the receiver.

"I can't," the boy said.

"Why?"

"I looked at the signature on the copy," Rehman said. "The blue blur at the end. You didn't even read the clauses."

"The clauses don't change the decision, Rehman."

"I am ashamed, uncle," the boy whispered. "I said those things on the terrace. The candle. The sun. It was the whiskey."

"It is alright."

"It is not," Rehman said. "I can't look at your face. I will handle the Barasat work from Alipore. Don't call me."

The line went dead.

Vikram held the receiver for a minute, the dial tone humming its dry, mechanical drone.

Rehman didn't call the next week.

Or the week after.

By the end of December, the Barasat manager called Bagbazar.

"Vikram babu," the manager said. "The salary release is pending. Rehman sir hasn't signed the bank authorization."

"Is he not in Alipore?"

"The house is locked, sir. The security guard said he left with two bags on Tuesday. He took a cab to the station."

Vikram took his bag.

He went to Alipore himself.

The apartment building was tall, the concrete walls painted cream, with large glass balconies reflecting the winter sun.

The security guard, an old Gorkha named Thapa, was sitting on a plastic chair near the gate.

He recognized Vikram from the newspaper photos.

"Rehman saab left," Thapa said.

"When?"

"Tuesday night, sir. He had two blue bags. The ones with the rusted zips."

"Did he leave an address?"

"No, sir. He just said he was going to Cuttack. He looked sick. His eyes were very dry, like he hadn't slept for weeks."

Vikram stood near the gate.

A silver sedan, identical to the one Rehman had driven, was parked near the wall.

It was covered in a thick layer of grey city dust, someone having traced a name into the dirt of the rear window with a finger.

Ummed.

He looked at the dusty window.

The Alipore house was locked.

The silver sedan was empty.

And Rehman was gone.

[End of Part 3]

PART 4

The press meet was held in the Bagbazar courtyard, under the shade of the largest neem tree.

Six plastic chairs.

One table with a green cloth.

Three reporters from the local Bengali dailies, and a photographer who spent ten minutes cleaning his lens with his shirt tail before taking a single shot of the courtyard well.

Sarita sat near the table.

She had returned from Delhi the night before, her walking stick now carrying a small brass cap at the bottom that made a ringing sound against the stone.

Vikram stood near the gate.

A woman was sitting on the second chair, holding a small notepad.

She had grey hair at the temples, her glasses thick, tied to a black cord around her neck.

She was talking to a silver-haired man beside her.

Aftab.

Her husband.

Vikram looked at her.

The shape of the eyelids was the same. The way she held the pen, the tip touching her lower lip as she read her notes.

Ira.

She looked up.

She saw him standing near the gate, his faded cotton shirt dusty from the sweep-work.

She stood up.

She didn't run. She walked slowly, her sandals clicking against the stone tiles he had reset himself.

"Vikram," she said.

"Ira," Vikram said.

Aftab had followed her. He stood beside her, his face quiet, nodding to Vikram with the respectful distance of a husband who had been told a version of a story a long time ago.

"This is Aftab," she said. "We edit the Cuttack weekly now."

"I know," Vikram said.

"I saw the shelter," she said, looking around the courtyard, at Ananya who was writing in the ledger. "It is good work, Vikram. The drivers at the crossing told me about the medicine delivery. They call you Budha Baba."

"They have many names," Vikram said.

He looked at her eyes.

"The cream-colored car," he said. "The one near the press building."

Ira looked down at her notepad.

"I sold it," she said, her voice dropping. "Two weeks after you left it. I used the money to clear my father's bank loan. It was enough to start the Cuttack weekly."

She looked at him again.

"Thank you, Vikram. For leaving it."

"Rohan's office," Vikram said. "The letters you sent."

Ira's brow furrowed.

"Letters? I never sent any letters, Vikram. I haven't spoken to Rohan since 1997."

Vikram felt a small, cold drop of sweat slide down his neck.

"The yellow envelope," he said. "From Cuttack. Rehman."

Ira looked at Aftab.

Aftab looked at Vikram, his eyes going from Vikram's face to the leather bag near the well.

"Rehman?" Ira asked. "Who is Rehman?"

"Your son," Vikram said. "The boy who came to work here."

Ira stared at him.

Not with anger.

With the deep, slow confusion of a journalist who has just realized a source is speaking in a language she doesn't know.

"Vikram," she said, her voice very quiet. "I never had a son."

"Aftab and I... we were married in ninety-eight. We didn't have children."

The telephone cabin on the corner of Bagbazar lane smelled of old directories and dry tobacco.

Vikram stood inside.

He dialled the number Rehman had called from.

The number he had written in the ledger margins.

A click.

Then the recorded voice of the exchange, dry and mechanical:

The number you have dialled does not exist. Please check the directory.

He dialled again.

The same voice.

He walked back to the shelter.

Ananya was sitting at her table.

"Ananya," Vikram said. "Rehman's canvas bag. The blue one. Where is it?"

"He took it, uncle," she said. "When he went to Alipore."

"The photo," Vikram said. "The one he showed you on his phone. The one of his mother."

Ananya looked at him, her pen stopping over the green ledger.

"He never showed me a photo, uncle."

"He did," Vikram said, his voice rising. "In the kitchen. The day he arrived."

"No, uncle," she said, her eyes large and quiet. "He only had the wooden horse. He said he found it near the well. He never showed a phone. He didn't have a phone."

Vikram walked into the study.

The yellow envelope was sitting on the teak wood desk, near the brass lion paperweight.

He picked it up.

He pulled out the ruled sheets of paper.

The paper was empty.

No Cuttack press details. No handwriting. No story of conversion.

*It was a property tax receipt from the municipal corporation, dated March 2015, sent to the **Ahuja Villa** address and forwarded by the clerk.*

The lawyer, Bannerjee, arrived at six.

He sat on the step of the well, his leather briefcase kept on his knees.

He didn't open it.

"The CEO transfer deed," Vikram said. "Where is it?"

"In my office, Vikram babu," the lawyer said.

"Whose name is on the recipient line?"

Bannerjee looked at the drumstick tree.

"Your name," he said.

"My name?"

"Yes. The power of attorney was drafted in your name. You signed it, but you left the second signature blank. You told me Rehman would sign in Alipore."

"He did sign," Vikram said. "He called me. He said he saw the blue blur."

*"Nobody signed, Vikram babu," the lawyer said, his voice dropping. "The papers are still in my briefcase. I went to Alipore. The apartment was registered in the name of **Ummmed Trust**, which is a subsidiary of Punarjeevan. The keys were with the security guard."*

He looked at Vikram properly now.

"The guard said you rented the flat three years ago. You paid the rent in advance from the Odisha account. Nobody ever lived there, Vikram babu."

"The silver sedan?"

"The sedan was bought by the trust," Bannerjee said. "You bought it yourself in 2018. It has been sitting in the Alipore garage since the day of purchase."

Vikram sat on the stone wall of the well.

The red tea was boiling in the kitchen, the smell of ginger coming through the window.

But the glass on the ledge was empty.

He looked at his hands, at the calluses, at the grey dirt under the nails.

The fourteen hundred crore was in Nandyal.

The seventy-six hundred crore was in Alipore.

But the boy with the blue canvas bag and the rusted zip was nowhere in the city.

He had never been.

[End of Part 4]

PART 5

The staff room of the Bagbazar shelter had seven chairs and one long wooden bench where the junior volunteers sat.

Vikram stood near the window.

The neem trees outside were losing their leaves, the yellow blades falling silent onto the courtyard stone.

"I am going," Vikram said.

Sarita looked up from the table.

She was holding a glass of red tea, her hands trembling slightly against the warm glass.

"Where?" she asked.

"Nowhere," Vikram said. "Just out."

"But the shelter, Vikram," one of the senior patients, an old tailor named Ghosh, said. "The Barasat license is still pending. The distributors won't talk to us if you're not here."

"They will talk to Sarita," Vikram said. "She has the register."

"We need you, Baba," Ananya said, from the corner of the bench.

She was eighteen now.

She was still holding the ledger with the green cloth cover, her fingers tracing the seam of the spine.

"The kids at the school ask when you are coming to tell the crow story. They have been waiting since Tuesday."

"Tell them the crow flew away," Vikram said.

He looked at her, his face quiet.

"I want to be a free bird, Ananya."

"Even a bird has a nest," Sarita said.

"Only when it is tired," Vikram said.

He picked up his small leather bag.

He had left the second shirt on the bench. He had only the clothes he wore — a faded cotton kurta and the rubber slippers he'd bought at the Shobhabazar market.

He walked out.

He didn't use the main wooden door.

He walked through the side corridor, passed the kitchen where the red tea was still simmering on the coal stove, and went out into the lane.

For three years, he lived on the streets of Bagbazar.

He slept on the verandah of the Ramkrishna Mission, his head resting on his rolled-up bag.

The monks knew him as the old man who swept the steps before the morning prayers.

They offered him dal and rice in the noon.

He ate what they gave, washed his plate at the tap, and sat near the river bank for the rest of the day.

The children near the school started calling him Budha Baba.

Not because he was old.

Because he had the time to sit on the concrete drain edge and listen to their stories about the street dogs and the broken kites.

He didn't have a phone.

If the shelter needed him, Ramu's nephew would walk down to the river bank and tell him.

But they rarely called.

They had learned to run the math themselves.

The call came on a Tuesday morning in July 2018.

Vikram was sleeping on the verandah of the Mission, the rain from the Hooghly river spraying light drops over his feet.

Ramu's nephew came running, his shirt wet, holding a plastic pouch containing Vikram's old Nokia phone.

"Baba," the boy said, out of breath. "Ananya called. From the shelter."

Vikram took the phone.

The screen was scratched, the battery showing only one bar of green light.

"Ananya?"

"Baba," her voice was fast, tight with the specific panic of the emergency ward. "It's Kavita. The girl from the Barasat branch. She got her report yesterday. She is at the bypass bridge. She wants to jump."

"I am coming," Vikram said.

He didn't take the bag.

He left it on the Mission verandah, near the sweeper's broom.

He ran.

His rubber slippers were thin, the soles sliding on the wet mud of the Bagbazar lanes.

The bypass bridge was two kilometers away.

When he reached, Kavita was standing on the concrete ledge of the railing, her hands holding the iron pipe, looking down at the railway tracks below.

The rain was heavier now, the water running fast along the concrete.

A crowd of truck drivers had gathered at a distance, shouting, but nobody had gone close.

Vikram walked onto the bridge.

He didn't shout.

He didn't tell her that life was beautiful.

He simply stood beside her on the ledge, his faded kurta soaked through, his feet cold in the slippers.

"The water is dirty," Vikram said, looking at the tracks.

Kavita turned her head slowly.

Her face was white, her eyes wet with the rain.

"I have the bad blood, Baba," she whispered.

"I know," Vikram said. "Ananya had it too. She is still writing the ledger."

He held out his hand.

His hand was rough, the calluses yellow and hard, the nails grey with river sand.

"Come," he said. "Ramu's nephew has the tea ready. It is cheap tea, but it is hot."

She looked at his hand.

She looked at the tracks below.

Then she stepped down.

She didn't cry. She simply took his hand, her fingers cold and trembling against his calluses.

Vikram led her to the ambulance the police had brought.

A local MLA, who had arrived in a white Ambassador car with a red light on the top, stepped out.

He recognized Vikram from the old Kolkata press meets.

"Ahujra saab," the MLA said, holding an umbrella over Vikram's head. "Get in. The car will drop you to the hospital."

Vikram pushed the umbrella aside.

"The car is too clean," Vikram said. "It will get wet."

He walked away.

He crossed the bypass road, his slippers sliding on the mud.

The rain had stopped for a moment, the sun coming through the grey clouds, turning the wet road into a line of shining silver.

Behind him, a crowd had gathered near the bridge.

A strike was happening, the local workers shouting slogans, throwing stones at the passing auto rickshaws.

A motorcycle came fast from the wrong side of the divider, its headlight off, its engine roaring over the shouts of the crowd.

Vikram didn't hear the horn.

He was looking at the well tap of the shelter visible between the buildings, thinking of the red tea that would be waiting.

A sharp, dry sound of brakes.

Then the impact.

He felt the road rising to meet his shoulder.

He felt his rubber slipper flying off his foot.

And then the darkness came, quiet and cold, like the shadow of the neem trees in the Bagbazar courtyard.

"Please... side... please... give a little side..."

The voice wasn't loud.

Yet it cut through the noise of the casualty corridor.

An old man lying on a stretcher, his white cotton shirt brown near the shoulder, one rubber slipper still remaining on his right foot.

The NGO girl walking beside him, her left elbow bleeding, her sleeve torn.

She bent down.

Removed the remaining slipper.

Placed both carefully under the stretcher.

"It doesn't look nice," she said. "Wearing only one slipper."

[End of Chapter VI]

CHAPTER VII: COLORLESS TEARS

PART 1

The morning shift at the hospital began at six.

The corridors had the grey, cold light of an early dawn that hadn't yet cleared the smoke from the railway yard.

Adarsh walked toward the casualty.

He hadn't slept more than two hours, his eyes carrying the dry, burning sensation of a long night.

The crowd near the ICU door had not dispersed.

They were still there.

The auto driver. The flower seller. The school teacher.

But they were no longer standing in a queue.

They were sitting on the floor, their backs against the green-painted wall, their hands empty.

Nobody was holding flowers today.

Ananya sat on the same chair, the walking stick with the red strip of cloth leaning against her shoulder.

She wasn't looking at the door.

She was looking at the leather slippers kept carefully under the stretcher frame near the wall.

Both slippers. Clean. Placed side by side.

Adarsh slowed his pace.

The ICU door was open.

Inside, the monitor on table nine was silent, the green screen blank, the power cord unplugged and wound around the metal stand.

The sheet on the bed was pulled all the way to the top.

A clean, white hospital sheet, showing only the outline of a thin shoulder and the long frame of the legs.

The senior nurse was standing near the medicine cabinet, sorting the unused ampoules of adrenaline back into the plastic tray.

She saw Adarsh.

She kept the tray down.

"At four-fifteen, sir," she said. "The pressure dropped. We gave the dopamine, but the heart was too tired."

Adarsh stood near the bed.

He didn't pull the sheet back.

As a doctor, he had pulled back a hundred sheets. He had checked the pupils, felt the neck for the carotid, signed the time of death on the margins of the file.

But he didn't touch this one.

He looked at the white outline.

The distance between the anatomy dissection table in 1995 and this silent ICU bed was twenty-three years.

He had spent the night thinking of the questions he would ask when Vikram woke.

Why didn't you write?

Where was the business?

Who was Rehman?

Now, the sheet was closed.

The questions had stayed in his head, and there was no other room where the answers would be spoken.

"A lady is waiting in the visitor's room," the nurse said, keeping the adrenaline box in the drawer.

"Dr. Sen. The psychiatrist from the Kolkata medical college. She had the patient's records from 2016."

Adarsh looked at the white sheet one last time.

Then he turned.

He walked out of the ICU, passed the crowd sitting against the wall, and went toward the visitor's wing.

The old tea seller at the corner of the corridor was starting his stove.

The blue flame groaned as it caught the coal.

Smelling of kerosene and the dry, cold air of the morning.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

Dr. Sen was sitting at the corner table of the visitor's room.

She was fifty, perhaps fifty-two, wearing a silk saree that had the dull grey color of river silt.

She had three folders on the table, their brown cardboard covers held together by red cotton strings.

"I expected you earlier, Dr. Tripathy," she said.

Adarsh sat in the wooden chair across.

"The shift took time," he said.

"Sarita brought him here in 2016," she said. "He had been found sitting in the Alipore garage, staring at the silver sedan for eight hours without moving."

Adarsh looked at the folders.

The notes were written in a quick, clinical hand.

"He told me about Rehman," she said. "He described the canvas bag, the way the boy painted the kitchen, even his Odia accent. He said the boy had Ira's eyes."

"Ira," Adarsh said.

"He carried her memory like a stone in his shoe. Every step hurt, but he had stopped trying to shake it out."

She turned a page. The paper made a dry rustle.

"The yellow envelope was real, but it was only a municipal tax receipt. Vikram needed a reason to let the boy in. So his mind read Ira's name on the cheap yellow paper."

"Why?"

"Because he was tired of the split," she said, looking out at the hospital parking lot. "One half of him had built the fourteen hundred crore. The other half had left the anatomy lab, leaving a textbook half-underlined. He wanted the well, but the tycoon in him couldn't stop building."

She tapped the folder.

"Rehman was the alternate choice. The boy who could buy the sedan, fly to Geneva, and run the business, while Vikram slept on the wooden bench in Bagbazar. Rehman was the one who could shout at him on the terrace."

"The terrace," Adarsh said. "The candle and the sun."

"It was Vikram's own voice," she said. "He had given the empire to Rohan. He had walked away. But even in Bagbazar, the MLA still called him **Ahuja saab**. He couldn't escape the name. He was guilty that his legacy followed him."

She closed the folder.

"The real Ira Sen appearing at the press meet broke the split. The moment she said she never had a son, Rehman had to disappear."

"Did he know?" Adarsh asked.

"He knew," she said. "He told me he signed the CEO transfer with a blue blur because the space for the second name was blank. He said: **I wanted to give the pen to Rehman. But Rehman had no hand to take it.**"

She stood up.

She tied the red string around the cardboard, the knot tight and neat.

"His case was simple, Dr. Tripathy. Some minds break because they are weak. His broke because it was too honest to keep the palace and the well at the same time."

She looked at him.

"His smiles were transparent," she said. "But his tears... they had no color."

Adarsh sat in the chair.

The visitor's room was silent now.

The lawyer's deeds were in Dalhousie Square, the Alipore house locked, the factory compound gates opening and closing.

But the case file on the table was the only thing that had his friend's name written on the cover.

"Thank you, doctor," Adarsh said.

She picked up the folders and left.

Her sandals made a quiet, clicking sound against the corridor floor, fading until only the scratching sound of the ceiling fan remained in the room.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

Rohan took the body back to Odisha.

The office had sent a private ambulance, the white Ambassador kind, the driver wearing the company uniform with the grey epaulettes on the shoulders.

Rohan didn't speak to Adarsh.

He stood near the casualty counter, signed the release forms, his signature neat and clear — the signature he had learned after Vikram left.

His hand didn't tremble today.

The red Nandyal dust had gone from his shoes, replaced by polished black leather that reflected the hospital corridor lights.

Ananya and Sarita left in the evening.

They had the Howrah train tickets.

"Come to Bagbazar, Dr. Tripathy," Sarita said at the gate.

"The neem trees are green now."

"I will come," Adarsh said.

He watched the auto rickshaw carry them toward the station.

Ananya was sitting in the back, the three-legged wooden horse kept on her lap, her hand holding the green ledger.

She didn't look back.

Adarsh returned to his room at eight.

The room was small, smelling of old paper and the tea he had left unfinished on the table.

He went to the cupboard.

He opened the lowest shelf, behind the old medical journals and the files of forgotten cases.

The pathology textbook was still there.

He pulled it out.

The cover was grey with the dust of twenty-two years, the corners frayed, the cardboard showing through the paper.

He opened it.

Chapter three. **Hepatic cirrhosis.**

The line was still there, the blue ink of Vicky's pen dry and faded, ending mid-sentence near the margin.

Decompensated liver function is marked by portal hypertension...

He closed the book.

He kept it on the table near his stethoscope.

Vikram had left the room.

He had left the white coat.

He had left the fourteen hundred crore.

He had left the seventy-six hundred crore.

Most people who wrote his obituary in the business weekly would write about the empire he had surrendered.

They would call him a loser.

A tycoon who couldn't keep his grip on the wheel.

A success that had gone soft at the end.

Adarsh walked to the window.

The hospital lights below were yellow, shining on the wet asphalt of the M.G. Road.

The auto rickshaws honked. The vendors shouted. The city went on.

But as he looked at his own white apron hanging on the wall, the blue thread stitching on the pocket — **Adarsh Tripathy** — still neat and clear after thirty years, he wondered.

Who is the loser?

He?

Or we, who sit in our comfortable chairs, making comfortable decisions, holding onto our names until the name is the only thing left of us?

He had no answer.

The book on the table was closed.

The window was dark.

And the story of Vikram Ahuja had ended exactly where it began — on a wooden bench, under the shadow of a neem tree, with a glass of red tea that had gone cold in the wind.

[End of Novel]